

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Mark

Mark 1:1

- Mark begins with an introduction. This gospel is about Jesus. In each story in Mark, we should ask, “What is Mark teaching about Jesus in this passage?”
- *Gospel*: This is a common term in Mark (see [1:14–15](#); [8:35](#); [10:29](#); [13:10](#); [14:9](#)). It can also be translated as *good news*. The gospel is the good news about Jesus. See study note on Mark 1:15.
- The Hebrew word *mashiakh* (Messiah) has the same meaning as the Greek term *christos* (Christ). Both mean “anointed one.”

In the Old Testament, the people of Israel anointed:

- priests ([Exodus 28:41](#); [Leviticus 16:32](#); [21:10](#)),
- kings ([2 Samuel 1:14](#), [16](#); [19:21](#); [Psalm 2](#)), and
- prophets ([1 Kings 19:16](#)).

They anointed them with olive oil to show the Lord’s presence, blessing, and authority for the tasks God gave them.

Over time, Israelites increasingly anticipated the Messiah, “the anointed one.” He would be a descendant of King David, who would be Israel’s king. The political associations of this title in the first century led Jesus to avoid openly declaring himself as the Messiah (see [Mark 3:11–12](#); [8:27–30](#); [14:61–63](#); [15:2](#), [26](#); [John 4:25–26](#)).

- *The Son of God*: This title emphasizes the special relationship between Jesus and God the Father ([Mark 1:11](#); [9:7](#); [12:4–6](#); [14:61–62](#)).

Mark 1:2–3

- Mark includes Old Testament prophecies (messages from God given long ago) to support his account of the good news about Jesus Christ. John the Baptist’s role as a prophet and messenger shows that Jesus is the promised Lord and king. He is the Christ (or Messiah, God’s chosen one) and the Son of God.
- *Isaiah*: Mark follows the Jewish practice of mentioning only the best-known source in a quotation. Here he names Isaiah, even though the quotation also includes ([Malachi 3:1](#); [Isaiah 40:3](#)).

Mark 1:2–8

This account does not focus mainly on John the Baptist, the messenger. Instead, it is about the one whom he announces as Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God ([1:1](#)).

Mark 1:3

John the Baptist was the *voice of one calling in the wilderness*, urging people to prepare for the Lord’s coming. In the book of Isaiah, this prophecy speaks of the coming of the Lord, the God of Israel. Here, it refers to the Lord Jesus (see [12:35–37](#)). The early church called itself “the Way,” likely referring to this promise (see [Acts 9:2](#); [19:9](#), [23](#); [22:4](#); [24:14](#), [22](#); compare [Acts 2:28](#); [18:25–26](#); [Romans 2:20](#); [2 Peter 2:2](#), [21](#)).

Mark 1:4

- John’s mission as the Lord’s messenger was to prepare people for the arrival of the Messiah (see [Luke 1:76–77](#)). He instructed them to confess their sins, seek God’s forgiveness, and be baptized. Those who did this were ready to receive the message of Jesus (see [Luke 7:29–30](#)).
- John was in the wilderness, likely the desert area around the Jordan River north of the Dead Sea. This shows he was the “voice” Isaiah mentioned ([Mark 1:3](#)).
- *preaching a baptism*: The exact origin of John’s baptism is uncertain. The Qumran community practiced a “baptism” when someone became a part of the community, which they repeated regularly. But John’s baptism was a one-time event. Jewish baptism for those converting to Judaism is another possible source, but it is more likely that such baptisms were not practiced until after John’s ministry.

Mark 1:5

All of ... Judea: John the Baptist attracted a lot of attention. Many people believed that there had been no prophet for over 400 years. So, prophets were associated with Israel’s past and the future reign of the Messiah.

John preached repentance (turning away from sin and returning to God), like the ancient prophets. He also dressed like the great prophet Elijah ([1:6](#)), whom God promised would return in the last days ([Malachi 4:5](#)).

Mark 1:6

- *camel’s hair, with a leather belt*: Compare with Elijah ([2 Kings 1:8](#)).
- John ate what was available in the wilderness. Locusts (a type of insect) were allowed as food by God’s law (compare [Leviticus 11:20–24](#)).

Mark 1:7

will come one: John knew he was preparing for the coming of the Messiah, but he did not yet know that Jesus was the Messiah (see [Luke 7:18–23](#)).

Mark 1:8

John's baptism prepared people for God's kingdom by calling them to repentance. The baptism of Jesus brought the gift of the Holy Spirit, through whom sinful people become God's children ([Romans 8:15–16](#); [1 Corinthians 12:13](#); [Galatians 4:6](#)).

Mark 1:9

- At this time, Jesus lived in Nazareth, a small town in lower Galilee ([Matthew 2:19–23](#); [Luke 2:39](#)). Jesus soon left Nazareth for Capernaum, a city on the Sea of Galilee ([Matthew 4:13](#)).
- *was baptized by John*: [Matthew 3:14–15](#) explains the reason Jesus received the baptism of repentance.

Mark 1:10

- The phrase *the heavens breaking open* shows that Jesus has a unique and direct relationship with God the Father. In [Mark 15:38](#), the same verb shows that believers also gain access to God through the death of Jesus.
- All four Gospels mention the Holy Spirit coming down on Jesus like a dove. The Spirit, who was active in the first creation, now works with Jesus to begin the new creation ([Genesis 1:2](#); [Romans 8:15–17](#); [1 Corinthians 6:11](#); [Ephesians 1:13–14](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:13](#)).

Mark 1:11

You are My beloved Son: By age twelve, Jesus was aware of his unique relationship with God the Father ([Luke 2:49](#)).

Mark 1:12–13

- *the Spirit drove Jesus* (compare [Matthew 4:1](#); [Luke 4:1](#)): he Spirit led Jesus into the wilderness. From the beginning of his ministry, Jesus defeated Satan and resisted temptation. His later acts of casting out demons ([Mark 1:21–34](#); [3:11–12](#); [5:1–20](#); [9:14–27](#)) show the results of that victory (see [3:27](#)).
- Jesus was tempted in the wilderness of Judea. In Scripture, the wilderness often has a sense of danger and evil because of Satan and wild animals ([Isaiah 13:19–22](#); [Ezekiel 34:25](#)). These animals included dogs, wolves, leopards, jackals, and bears.
- The *forty days* remind us of Israel's forty years of testing in the wilderness. Israel failed, but Jesus succeeded. He resisted temptation without sinning ([Hebrews 2:18](#); [4:15](#); see also [James 1:3, 12](#); [1 Peter 1:7](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)).

Mark 1:14

Jesus began his ministry after John was arrested by Herod Antipas (the ruler of Galilee). There was some overlap

between their ministries ([John 3:22–24](#); [4:1–2](#)), but most of the ministry of Jesus happened after John's.

John belongs mainly to the old order (the time before the full ministry of Jesus; [Matthew 11:7–14](#)), while Jesus brings the new. Both men carried out God's plan, and both were arrested and put to death ([Mark 6:14–29](#); [9:31](#); [10:33](#)).

Jesus started preaching in Galilee after John's arrest. But [John 2:13–4:43](#) suggests Jesus had an earlier ministry in Judea.

Mark 1:14–15

This summary introduces [1:14–3:6](#). Such summaries help hearers understand what follows (see also [3:7–12](#); [6:6](#)). Most of Mark's original audience would have heard the Gospel read aloud.

Mark 1:15

- The preaching of Jesus is summarized in his announcement that the kingdom of God had come. He called people to repent (turn away from sin and turn to God) and believe the good news about the Messiah ([1:1](#)).
- The kingdom of God is not associated with a place or land. It began with Jesus himself and continues through his followers.
- Because the kingdom of God has come, people must repent and have faith in God's good news. In the time of Jesus, this good news meant that God's reign had arrived through the Messiah. For Mark's later audience, it also included the news of the death, resurrection, ascension of Jesus, and his promised return ([15:1–16:8](#)).

All people, both Jews and non-Jews (called Gentiles), need God's forgiveness through repentance and faith in Jesus.

Mark 1:16–20

The call of the two pairs of brothers (Simon and Andrew, and James and John) came after they had already met Jesus earlier ([John 1:35–42](#)).

Mark 1:17

Mark uses the invitation of Jesus, *Come, follow Me* ([1:20](#); [8:34](#)) and the repeated idea of people following him ([1:18](#); [2:14–15](#); [3:7](#); [5:24](#)) to describe what it means to be his disciple (see "Following Jesus" Theme Note).

Mark 1:19–20

James son of Zebedee and his brother John ... left their father Zebedee: Jesus later taught that his followers would do similar things ([8:34–35](#); [Matthew 10:37–39](#)).

Mark 1:21

Mark begins his first account of an exorcism (driving or casting out an evil spirit) with Jesus and his companions going into the synagogue in Capernaum. Jesus teaching there suggests that he was already known as a teacher, so he was invited to speak (compare [Acts 13:15](#)).

Mark 1:21–28

Jesus driving out evil spirits shows who he is and his power over Satan (see study notes on Mark 1:12–13 and 3:27; see also [1:34, 39](#); [3:11–12, 22](#); [5:1–20](#); [6:13](#); [7:24–30](#); [9:14–29](#)).

Mark 1:22

The teachers of religious law were professional scribes (scholars who taught, copied, and interpreted Jewish law for the people). They were primarily associated with the Pharisees. The authority of the scribes came from quoting other scribes (compare [Matthew 5:21–48](#)). When Jesus taught, the people were amazed because he spoke and acted with real authority (see [Mark 1:27](#); [5:20](#); [6:2](#); [7:37](#); [10:24–32](#); [11:18](#); [15:5](#)).

Mark 1:23–24

- The demon spoke through the man who was possessed by an evil spirit ([1:24](#)). In the Gospels, demons are often associated with disease ([9:17, 27](#); [Matthew 17:15](#)) and self-destructive behavior ([Mark 1:26](#); [5:2–5](#); [9:17–18, 20–22](#)).

Demons know who Jesus is ([1:34](#)). They constantly identify him as *the Holy One of God* (for similar phrases see [3:11](#); [5:7](#)).

- In saying *us*, the evil spirit spoke on behalf of all demons. It recognized that Jesus has full authority and understood that he had come to oppose and destroy evil.

Mark 1:25

- Jesus did not need to shout or use magic words. He spoke with the authority of the Son of God, and the evil spirit obeyed ([1:1](#)).
- *Be silent!*: Jesus commanded the evil spirit not to reveal his identity. This is an example of the “messianic secret.” This term describes places in Mark where Jesus tells demons or people not to reveal who he is ([1:25, 34](#); [3:11–12](#); [8:30](#); [9:9](#)).

Mark 1:26

The *loud shriek* and *convulsions* caused by the *unclean spirit* were cries of defeat as it left the man (see also [1:27](#); [5:13](#); [9:26](#); compare [15:37](#)).

Mark 1:27–28

- The amazement caused by this exorcism quickly led to the spread of the news about Jesus.

- *What is this? A new teaching with authority!*: People saw the healings and exorcisms that Jesus did as being part of his teaching ([1:21–22, 27](#); compare [1:38–39](#); [3:14–15](#); [6:2, 5, 12–13, 30](#)).

Mark 1:29–30

Simon, also called Peter, was married (see [1 Corinthians 9:5](#)).

Mark 1:31

Jesus healed Simon’s mother-in-law immediately (see also [1:40–45](#); [2:1–12](#); [3:1–6](#); [5:25–34](#); [7:31–37](#); [8:22–26](#); [10:46–52](#)).

Mark 1:32–34

These public healings happened after sunset, following the Sabbath day ([1:21, 29](#)). Many people witnessed them (see also [1:39](#); [3:10–11](#); [6:5, 53–56](#)).

Mark 1:33

Jesus became more popular with the crowds (also in [1:37, 39, 45](#)). Meanwhile, the leaders increasingly rejected him ([2:1–3:6](#)).

Mark 1:34

they knew who He was: See [1:23–25](#).

Mark 1:35

Despite his busy ministry, Jesus made time to pray ([6:46](#); [14:32–39](#)). Mark emphasizes how important prayer was in the life of Jesus (see also [Luke 3:21](#); [6:12](#); [9:18, 28–29](#); [11:1–4](#); [18:1](#); [22:32](#)).

Mark 1:38–39

- Prayer equipped Jesus to preach, teach, heal, and drive out demons ([1:35](#)).
- The mission of Jesus in Galilee focused on preaching in the synagogues, where he took the opportunity to speak ([1:21](#); [Luke 4:16–30](#)). The apostle Paul later took advantage of this same opportunity ([Acts 13:5, 14–15](#); [14:1](#); [16:13](#); [17:1](#)).
- Jesus relied on the Jewish practice of kindness to strangers when he traveled (compare [Mark 6:10](#); [Genesis 18:1–8](#); [19:1–8](#); [Luke 10:7](#); [Hebrews 13:2](#); [3 John 1:5–8](#)).
- The region of Galilee measured about 65 kilometers (40 miles) north to south and 40 kilometers (25 miles) east to west. In the time of Jesus, Galilee was ruled by Herod Antipas.

Mark 1:40

Leprosy refers to several skin diseases (or even mildew in a building). An infected person was considered ceremonially unclean and was excluded from

family and society ([Leviticus 13:45–46](#); [Numbers 12:9–12](#); [2 Chronicles 26:16–21](#); [Luke 17:12](#)).

Mark 1:41

Jesus was willing to touch a ceremonially unclean leper. This act shows the new order of the kingdom of God ([1:15](#); [5:25–34](#); [Luke 7:36–50](#); see [Matthew 10:8](#); [11:5](#)).

Mark 1:43–45

- Jesus instructed the man to visit the priest to confirm his healing and make the required sacrificial offering. This would act as public proof of his healing.
- Despite the severe warning Jesus gave, the man went and told people what happened to him. As a result, Jesus could not enter the town and had to preach in more remote places. Jesus became widely known, and people from many places came to see him ([3:7–8](#)).

Mark 2:1

He was home: See [Matthew 4:13](#). The large crowd shows that Jesus was popular.

Mark 2:1–12

This controversy story is also a miracle story. It includes both a dispute and an act of healing or power.

Because it contains a miracle, it connects with the earlier group of miracle stories in [1:21–45](#).

Mark 2:1–3.6

Five controversy stories ([2:1–12](#), [13–17](#), [18–22](#), [23–28](#); [3:1–6](#)) are grouped together because they share a common theme. Each story shows a conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders. In these accounts, Jesus says or does things that challenge their beliefs and practices. These stories show the great authority that Jesus has.

Mark 2:4

- *through the crowd:* See [2:1](#).
- Houses at that time usually had flat roofs made of mud, thatch (dry plant material), and branches. The men made an opening by digging through the roof.

Mark 2:5

- Jesus saw the faith of *the paralytic* and the four men who brought him.
- *your sins are forgiven:* Those listening understood the words of Jesus as a claim to having the same authority as God (see [2:6–10](#); [Luke 7:48–49](#)).

Mark 2:6–7

Only God can forgive sins, yet Jesus had authority to do so ([2:10](#)).

Mark 2:9–11

Which is easier: to say ... ‘Your sins are forgiven’: This claim cannot be directly proved or disproved, while the claim to heal can be. Jesus showed his ability to heal in order to show his authority to forgive.

Mark 2:12

We have never seen anything like this!: Mark often shows how Jesus amazed people ([1:22](#), [27](#); [4:41](#); [6:50–51](#)).

Mark 2:13–15

- Levi was also called Matthew (see [Matthew 9:9–10](#)). Certain people are known by two names in the New Testament (for example, Simon is also called Peter; Saul is also called Paul; Judas son of James is also called Thaddaeus, see study note on [Mark 3:18](#)).
- This type of tax collector (Greek *telōnēs*) collected sales taxes, customs, and road tolls, unlike those who collected the poll tax ([12:14](#)). Other Jews disliked local tax collectors like Levi because they often charged the public more than they owed ([Luke 19:8](#)). As agents of the Romans, the Jews considered them to be traitors. Jesus invited Levi, a tax collector, to follow him, joining Peter, Andrew, James, and John ([Mark 1:16–20](#)).

Mark 2:13–17

This controversy is about Jesus spending time with sinners who had a bad reputation, such as tax collectors, and eating with them.

Mark 2:16

The Pharisees, who were teachers of religious law, regarded Jesus eating with sinners as him accepting them as friends ([Luke 15:1–2](#); [19:5, 7](#); [Acts 11:2–18](#); [Galatians 2:11–12](#)). Jesus showed that these tax collectors and sinners were welcome in the kingdom of God.

In his ministry, Jesus invited both Jews and Gentiles to share in the kingdom of God ([Mark 5:1–20](#); [7:24–30](#); compare [Matthew 8:5–13](#); [Luke 7:1–10](#); [John 4:43–54](#)).

Mark 2:17

Jesus answered his opponents with a well-known proverb. He compared himself to a doctor and sinners to sick people. Salvation is for those who know they are sinners, not for those who think they are righteous ([Luke 16:15](#); [18:9](#); [Romans 3:23](#)).

Mark 2:18–22

This controversy deals with fasting, which Jesus did not practice with his disciples. The Pharisees regularly fasted two days a week, on Mondays and Thursdays ([Luke 18:12](#)). Jews often fasted when mourning or specially seeking the Lord's favor ([Leviticus 16:29–31](#); [1 Samuel 31:13](#); [2 Samuel 1:12](#); [12:21–23](#); [Ezra 8:23](#); [Esther 4:3](#); [Matthew 6:16](#)).

Mark 2:19–20

Jesus was like a *bridegroom* at his wedding, so fasting was not appropriate. It was a time to celebrate ([Luke 15:23–25, 32](#)). The disciples would fast after Jesus went up to heaven (see [Acts 13:2–3](#); [14:23](#)).

Mark 2:21–22

The old customs of the old covenant do not fit with the new arrival of God's kingdom. People know that a *patch of unshrunk cloth* sewn on old clothing will tear the old cloth as it shrinks. In the same way, cracking *old wineskins* will burst when new wine ferments in them. The fasting of the old ways cannot be mixed with the feasting that comes with the new.

Mark 2:23–28

In this controversy, Jesus and his disciples are accused of breaking the Sabbath ([Exodus 20:8–11](#)). Picking grain by hand in another person's field was lawful ([Deuteronomy 23:25](#)). The charge was that by rubbing the chaff from the kernels, the disciples were working on the Sabbath, which was forbidden ([Exodus 34:21](#)).

Mark 2:25–26

Jesus answered by referring to an event in the life of King David ([1 Samuel 21](#)). David and his men ate the sacred bread, the twelve loaves in the tabernacle that only priests were allowed to eat (see [Leviticus 24:5–9](#)). In that sense, they did what the law did not permit. But Jesus showed that a deeper principle was also at work ([Mark 2:27–28](#)).

Mark 2:27–28

Since Jesus is the Lord of humanity ([1 Corinthians 15:25–28](#); [Ephesians 1:20–22](#); [Philippians 2:9–11](#)) and since the Sabbath was made to meet the needs of people, Jesus is *Lord even of the Sabbath*. Like when Jesus claimed authority to forgive sins, this also showed that he claimed authority that belongs to God ([Mark 2:7](#)).

Mark 3:1–2

The scene again involves a synagogue, probably in Capernaum ([1:21, 29](#)). The man with a withered hand was present

on the Sabbath ([3:1–2](#)). The enemies of Jesus wanted to use this situation against him. If he healed the man, they could accuse him, so they watched him closely.

Mark 3:1–6

This story ends the collection of controversy stories ([2:1–3:6](#)). Like the previous story, Jesus argues with the Pharisees about the Sabbath. As in the first story, the controversy involves a healing ([2:1–12](#)).

Mark 3:3–4

- Jesus challenged his enemies' belief that God did not allow doing good works on the Sabbath (see [Luke 13:10–17](#)).
- *to save life or to destroy it*: This might refer to an incident in which the Maccabees decided to fight if attacked on the Sabbath ([1 Maccabees 2:32–41](#)). These great Jewish heroes were willing to kill on the Sabbath day. But the Pharisees did not allow good works on that day. The question Jesus asked embarrassed them. It shamed them into silence, but they still refused to change ([Mark 3:5](#)).

Mark 3:5–6

Those who opposed Jesus were stubborn and would not listen to good reasoning. Instead of changing, they began to plan how to kill him (see also [11:18](#); [12:12](#); [14:1–2](#), [10–11](#)).

Mark 3:7–12

- Jesus went to the lake (the Sea of Galilee), which prepares for the events in [4:1–5:43](#). The large crowd that came to see John the Baptist ([1:7](#)) was smaller than the crowd that came to see Jesus.
- Idumea was a region in southern Judea, settled by the Edomites after the exile in Babylon.
- Tyre and Sidon were Phoenician cities on the Mediterranean coast that Jesus later visited ([7:24, 31](#)).

Mark 3:9

The boat likely belonged to Peter and Andrew or James and John. The crowd wanted to see Jesus so much that he needed to avoid being crushed by the people ([4:1](#); [5:24, 31](#)).

Mark 3:10

Jesus healed many people that day. He might have healed all the sick (see [Matthew 12:15](#)).

Mark 3:11–12

The *unclean spirits* knew who Jesus was ([1:34](#); see also [1:22](#); [5:7](#)). But Jesus did not want people to know his identity.

Mark 3:13–19

The scene shifts to a mountain. Mark describes how Jesus called his disciples to come to him. This is similar to God's call to Old Testament prophets ([Exodus 3:14–22](#); [1 Samuel 3:4–14](#); [Jeremiah 1:5–19](#)).

Mark 3:14–15

Jesus chose 12 men to represent Israel's 12 tribes and to announce that the kingdom of God had arrived. He called them apostles. The Greek word *apostoloi* refers to people sent on a special mission.

Jesus chose them to travel with him and to be sent out (Greek *apostellō*) to preach and cast out demons. They represented Jesus and had his authority.

Mark 3:16–18

- Simon and Andrew were brothers, just like James and John ([1:16–20](#)).
- *Peter* is the Greek version of the Aramaic word *kepa'*, which means "rock."

Mark 3:17

whom He named Boanerges, meaning "Sons of Thunder": This likely describes their character. It may suggest strong emotions, boldness, or quick reactions. For example, they once wanted to call down fire on a village that rejected Jesus (see [Luke 9:53–54](#)).

Mark 3:18

Philip is fifth on all four lists of the twelve disciples ([Matthew 10:1–4](#); [Luke 6:12–16](#); [Acts 1:13](#)). James son of Alphaeus (not the son of Zebedee and brother of John) is always ninth. Bartholomew might be Nathanael ([John 1:43–51](#)). Matthew is probably Levi, the tax collector ([Mark 2:14](#); [Matthew 9:9](#)). Thomas is also called Didymus (a Greek word meaning "twin," [John 11:16](#); [20:24](#); [21:2](#)). The New Testament does not explain this name further. Thaddeus is missing from Luke's list ([Matthew 10:3](#)). He might be Judas, the son of James ([Luke 6:16](#); [Acts 1:13](#)).

The presence of a government official (Matthew) and an anti-government activist (Simon the Zealot) among the twelve apostles shows the ability of Jesus to change people and overcome the natural hostility between them.

Mark 3:19

- Identifying Judas as *Ischriot* suggests that Mark wanted to avoid confusing him with another Judas ([Luke 6:16](#); [Acts 1:13](#)). The name *Ischriot* likely comes from the Hebrew phrase *'ish qeriyoth*, meaning "man of Kerioth" (a town in Judea).

- *who betrayed Jesus:* See [Mark 14:10–11](#), [43–46](#).

Mark 3:20

Jesus and his disciples could not even find time to eat. This shows how large the crowds were and how popular Jesus had become ([3:7–9](#)).

Mark 3:20–35

This story about Jesus and his family ([3:20–21](#) and [31–35](#)) surrounds a controversy story about Jesus driving out demons ([3:22–30](#)). This arrangement connects his family with the religious leaders, since both groups misunderstand him and stand against him.

Mark 3:21

He is out of his mind: Mark does not explain whether the attempt by the family of Jesus to seize him was motivated by sincere but misguided concern, or by hostility. The brothers and sisters of Jesus were not among his followers until after his resurrection ([3:31–35](#); [John 7:3–5](#)). [First Corinthians 15:7](#) mentions James, the brother of Jesus, who became a leader of the Jerusalem church ([Acts 15:13–21](#)).

Mark 3:22

The *scribes ... from Jerusalem* claimed Jesus was crazy because they believed Satan possessed him (see study note on [1:22](#)) (Greek *Beelzeboul*; see study note on [Matthew 10:25](#)). The opponents of Jesus said his ability to perform miracles came from Satan (see the Jewish rabbinic work, *Sanhedrin* 3:43a, where they credit the working of miracles to magic).

Mark 3:23–27

Jesus showed that this charge made no sense by using several examples. Satan would not work against himself.

Mark 3:27

Jesus explained his power to drive out demons by saying someone stronger than Satan had arrived and could take control of Satan's house ([1:7](#)). Jesus, the Messiah and the Son of God, was introducing God's kingdom and rescuing people from Satan's power ([1:1](#)).

Mark 3:28–30

- The phrase *Truly I tell you* often introduces the sayings of Jesus and emphasizes their importance (see also [8:12](#); [9:1](#), [41](#); [10:15](#), [29](#); [11:23](#); [12:43](#); [13:30](#); [14:9](#), [18](#), [25](#), [30](#)).
- *the sons of men will be forgiven all sins and blasphemies:* One sin has eternal consequences. This is blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. To blaspheme the Holy Spirit means attributing the work of God to an *unclean spirit* (an evil spirit). Resisting and rejecting God's work in this way

prevents the convicting work of the Spirit, which leads to repentance, faith in God, and forgiveness of sin (see study notes on Matthew 12:31–32; compare [Hebrews 6:4–6](#); [1 John 5:16–17](#)).

Mark 3:31–35

- Mark returns to the story from [3:20–21](#).
- *Your mother and brothers*: Many people understand the brothers of Jesus to be children born to Joseph and Mary after Jesus was born (see also [6:3](#); [Matthew 1:25](#); [12:46](#); [John 19:26–27](#)). Some interpreters think they were Joseph’s children from an earlier marriage or the cousins of Jesus. They hold this view because of the Roman Catholic belief that Mary remained a virgin for her whole life.

Mark 3:33–34

In God’s Kingdom, one’s true relatives are determined not by blood but by a faith relationship (see also [10:29–30](#)).

Mark 3:35

Doing God’s will includes repentance from sin, faith in God, and following Jesus ([1:15](#), [18](#), [20](#)).

Mark 4:1

Jesus again uses a boat to avoid the press of the crowd when he is teaching ([3:9](#); [Luke 5:2–3](#)).

Mark 4:1–34

In this section, Mark gathers several teaching parables of Jesus. A parable is a short story that teaches a spiritual truth.

Mark 4:2

Parables are often stories ([Luke 15:11–32](#); [18:1–8](#)) but can also be:

- proverbs (short, wise sayings that teach a general truth; [Mark 3:24–25](#); [Luke 4:23](#)),
- similes and metaphors ([Matthew 5:14](#); [10:16](#)),
- riddles ([Mark 7:15](#); [14:58](#)),
- comparisons ([Matthew 13:33](#); [Luke 15:3–7](#)),
- examples ([Luke 10:30–35](#); [12:16–21](#)), or
- allegories (metaphors with specific symbols representing each part of the story; [Mark 4:3–9](#); [12:1–12](#)).

Mark 4:3–9

The collection begins with the longest parable and its interpretation ([4:13–20](#)). The different types of soil represent different ways people respond to God’s message.

Mark 4:10

The scene changes from Jesus teaching a large crowd from a boat to being alone with *the Twelve and those around Him*. They ask Jesus about all the parables ([4:33–34](#)), not just this one.

Mark 4:11–12

- The true followers of Jesus could understand the secret of the kingdom of God. They knew the kingdom had arrived ([1:14–15](#)). They knew that the Christ, the Son of God, was among them ([1:1](#)). To *those on the outside*, it seemed like riddles.
- When Jesus answered the disciples’ question, he showed that he used parables to keep outsiders from understanding. This was so that they would be unable to repent and be forgiven.

The quotation from [Isaiah 6:9–10](#) in the Greek Old Testament version implies this was a deliberate judgment on the hearers. Jesus taught in parables, and outsiders did not believe. This fulfilled what the Scriptures had said would happen.

The teaching of Jesus about the Kingdom of God was sensitive (it could sound like a political threat and worry Roman rulers). Because of this, teaching in parables helped make his message less likely to cause conflict.

Mark 4:13

If people who heard Jesus could not understand the parable, they might not receive the gift of belonging to God’s Kingdom. But even his own disciples needed Jesus to explain the parables.

Mark 4:14–20

The explanation of the parable of the four soils uses an allegory (a story where each part has a deeper meaning). The *farmer* represents someone who shares God’s word ([4:14](#)). The four types of *soil* represent different ways people respond to that message.

The main point of the parable is that people should be like *good soil* and listen to God’s word ([4:9](#)). Only those who *produce a crop* (show a changed life) and continue faithfully to the end will be saved ([13:13](#); [8:35](#); [Revelation 2:10–11](#)).

Mark 4:21

A *lamp* is lit to shine and provide light, not to stay hidden. Citizens of the kingdom of God must display the light of the good news about Jesus ([4:17](#)).

Mark 4:21–25

These sayings connect with the call to listen carefully (4:9, 23–24) and with the difference between insiders and outsiders (4:11–12, 24–25). They show how people in God’s kingdom will live.

Mark 4:22–23

One day, the lamp (that is, Jesus; compare John 8:12) will reveal everything hidden. This includes every thought and secret action (Mark 13:26; 14:62; see Philippians 2:10–11). The time to listen is now, before this happens (Mark 4:9).

Mark 4:24

Those who listen and respond will gain more understanding. But “those on the outside” (4:11–12) will experience greater darkness (2 Corinthians 3:14–16).

Mark 4:26–29

- This parable focuses on the seed and how it grows over time.
- Just as the earth produces crops on its own, the completion (final coming) of God’s kingdom does not depend on human effort.
- *first the stalk, then the head, then the grain that ripens within*: These describe the normal stages of a seed’s growth.

Mark 4:26–34

Mark now gives additional seed parables (see 4:3–20). They all focus on “the mystery of the kingdom of God” (4:11). The parables of the seed growing secretly (4:26–29) and the mustard seed (4:30–32) show different stages of seed growth.

The kingdom of God is hidden (4:21). But growth is certain (4:26–29). The outcome will be great (4:32).

Mark 4:29

Harvest time is like the final coming of God’s kingdom. A *sickle* often represents the final judgment (Jeremiah 50:16; Joel 3:13; Revelation 14:14–19).

Mark 4:30–32

Jesus contrasts a very small beginning with a large result. The mustard seed was known to be very small, almost the smallest seed people commonly used (see Matthew 17:20).

Mark 4:33–34

- Mark’s summary of this section shows that 4:3–32 is a collection of parables. It is not a record of what Jesus taught on one specific day in the order in which he taught it.

- Jesus privately explained the parables to the disciples. This shows that they were not outsiders, even though they sometimes did not understand (compare 4:13).

Mark 4:35–41

- This passage focuses on the greatness of Jesus Christ, the Son of God. The authority of Jesus over the forces of nature showed that he is divine (truly God).
- *the other side*: The eastern side of the Sea of Galilee was the region of the Gerasenes (5:1).
- The presence of other boats following him shows how popular Jesus had become.

Mark 4:35–5.43

The three miracle stories in this section are connected by:

- a shared location (the Sea of Galilee),
- the presence of the disciples,
- the use of a boat, and
- a common theme, “*Who is this*” (4:41).

Mark 4:38

Jesus was likely asleep at the back of the boat, using a sandbag as a pillow. In 1986, archaeologists found a boat from the time of Jesus in the mud near the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee. It is 8 meters long (26.5 feet), 2.2 meters wide (7.5 feet), and 1.37 meters deep (4.5 feet). It has a raised stern. It could hold up to 15 people.

Mark 4:39–40

The disciples still lacked faith in Jesus (4:41), even though they had many chances to experience his power and authority (1:21–34, 40–45; 2:1–12; 3:1–5).

Mark 4:41

- The disciples were very afraid. This is a common response to Jesus in Mark (5:15, 33; 6:50; 9:32; 10:32; 11:18; 16:8).
- *Who is this*: Mark’s audience already knows that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God (1:1, 11, 24; 3:11).

Mark 5:1

in the region of the Gerasenes: The exact location is uncertain because of differences in the manuscripts and geography.

Manuscript evidence supports *Gerasa*, a city in this region located 59.5 kilometers (37 miles) southeast of the Sea of Galilee (5:13).

Some manuscripts read *Gadarenes*. Gadara was eight kilometers (five miles) southeast of the Sea of Galilee.

A few manuscripts read *Gergesenes*. The town of Gergesa was on a steep bank on the Sea of Galilee’s eastern shore.

Mark 5:1–20

Jesus and the disciples reached the other side of the lake, finishing the journey started in 4:35. As in 1:21–28 and 3:11, the demons recognized that Jesus was the Son of the Most High God (1:34). For the first time in the Gospel of Mark, a Gentile was healed by Jesus (see study note on 5:10–13; compare 7:24–30).

Mark 5:2–5

Mark focuses on Jesus. The evil spirit was strong, but Jesus had even greater authority (5:6–13).

Mark 5:6–8

- Despite the man’s terrible condition, the arrival of Jesus gave him hope. He ran and knelt before Jesus, asking for help.
- *Son of the Most High God*: Evil spirits know who Jesus really is (1:24, 34; 3:11).
- There was no struggle. Jesus was in control, and the *unclean spirit* obeyed him. Torture is the final judgment awaiting unclean spirits (Matthew 8:29; Luke 8:31).

Mark 5:9

A *legion* was a Roman military unit of 5,000–6,000 men. Here it describes the presence of many evil spirits.

Mark 5:10–13

The spirits kept begging Jesus, which shows his authority over them. Jesus allowed them to enter a herd of about 2,000 pigs. The pigs show that this was Gentile (non-Jewish) territory.

Some people focus on the loss of the pigs or ask why Jesus allowed the demons to destroy them. But Mark and his audience focused on how Jesus saved the man.

Mark 5:15–16

The change in the man shows the power Jesus has to save. Before, the man had been controlled by evil spirits. Now he was restored.

Mark 5:17

The frightened people asked Jesus to go away. Fear and amazement are frequent responses to the mighty acts of Jesus (see 1:22, 27; 2:12; 4:41; 6:50–51). People reacted in different ways to the saving work of Jesus (see 4:14–20).

Mark 5:18

Unlike his neighbors, the man experienced God’s grace and wanted *to go with Him* (literally *that he might be with him*; see 3:14).

Mark 5:19–20

- Jesus wanted the man to tell others about the great things *the Lord* had done for him. Thus, Mark identifies Jesus as *the Lord*.
- *tell them how much*: Unlike other times, Jesus did not hide his identity, possibly because it was safer in this non-Jewish area (see 3:11–12).
- *the Decapolis*: See study note on Matthew 4:24–25.

Mark 5:21–22

When Jesus had again crossed by boat to the other side ... A synagogue leader named Jairus arrived: Jairus organized the worship services at the synagogue and represented the Jewish community to the outside world (compare Acts 13:15).

Mark 5:21–43

Two healing miracles are connected by the need for faith (5:34, 36). The story of Jairus’s daughter begins, then the account of the woman with constant bleeding comes in the middle (5:25–34), and then the story of Jairus’s daughter continues. This pattern places the two stories together and connects them (see Mark Book Introduction, “Literary Features”). During the delay caused by the woman’s healing, Jairus’s daughter died (5:35–43).

Mark 5:23

The father wanted Jesus to heal her physically (Greek *so that she might be saved*; see 3:4; 5:28, 34; 6:56; 10:52; 15:30–31).

Mark 5:24–34

As Jesus heads to Jairus’s home, followed by a large crowd, Mark introduces a woman in the crowd who suffers from constant bleeding. This condition not only harms her health but also makes her ceremonially unclean. This prevents her from participating in normal community life (see Leviticus 15:25–27). She is an example of the faith that Jairus should have.

Mark 5:27–29

The woman’s faith led her to believe that touching the clothing that Jesus was wearing would heal her, and it happened right away (5:34).

Mark 5:33–34

The woman felt afraid, not because she was guilty, but because she realized she had witnessed a powerful miracle from God. Unlike the fear of the people in the region of the Gerasenes (5:15–17), her fear was positive and led to Jesus blessing her. She experienced God’s grace and salvation.

Mark 5:35–43

Since Jairus had left home, his daughter had died. Jesus reassured Jairus that, despite the death of his daughter and the seeming hopelessness of the situation, Jairus should not be afraid but have faith in Jesus.

Mark 5:36

just believe: Like the woman did (5:28).

Mark 5:37

Peter, James, and John became the closest followers of Jesus (see 3:16–17; 9:2; 14:33).

Mark 5:38

the commotion ... weeping and wailing loudly: These things the messengers' report and emphasized the hopelessness of the situation. Such displays of grief were common at funerals in the time of Jesus, where people often hired professionals to sadly cry (see Matthew 9:23).

Mark 5:39

Sleep is a metaphor for death (John 11:11; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–15). The child is not dead because Jesus will resurrect her. She is only *asleep* and will soon “wake up” and continue her life. The same Greek word translated here as *asleep* refers to death in Matthew 27:52; Acts 7:60; 13:36; 1 Corinthians 15:6, 18, 20, 51; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–15.

Mark 5:40

The crowd did not understand what Jesus meant. They laughed at him, knowing the girl had died. He made them all leave, probably to keep them from discouraging the parents any further.

Mark 5:41

Mark translates *Talitha kum* for his Greek-speaking audience as “*Little girl, I say to you, get up!*” These Aramaic words are not magical. They are simply what Jesus said when he raised the girl. Aramaic was his native language. Mark likely learned the story in Aramaic while in Jerusalem.

Mark 5:42

Jesus showed his power over death when the little girl stood up and walked immediately. She did not need time to recover. The change was instant and complete.

Mark 5:43

- After the miracle, there is a command not to tell anyone about it (see 3:11–12).

- *give her something to eat:* The Lord, who controls creation, demons, illness, and death, also cares about the daily needs of his creatures.

Mark 6:1–2

- The teaching of Jesus amazed the people because of his wisdom and his ability to heal and drive out demons.
- “*Where did this man get?*”: His early life in Nazareth had not prepared them to accept him as a teacher and healer who spoke and acted with authority.

Mark 6:1–6

Nazareth's rejection of Jesus stands in sharp contrast to the faith shown by others. The few miracles he did there also contrast with the greater displays of power seen in other places.

Mark 6:3–4

- The people of Nazareth saw Jesus only as a carpenter (literally *craftsman*).
- *He is just a carpenter, the son of Mary:* Calling Jesus *the son of Mary* instead of the son of Joseph likely means Joseph had died by then.
- *brother ... his sisters:* See study note on 3:31–35.
- *They were very offended:* They believed Jesus was pretending to be someone he could not possibly be.

Mark 6:5–6

- Faith and healing are often connected in Mark (2:5; 5:34, 36; 9:23–24; 10:52). The miracles of Jesus were not performances but miraculous signs of God's kingdom. To enter this kingdom and receive its benefits, one must repent and have faith (1:15).
- Jesus healed some sick people, but the lack of faith in his own village amazed Jesus. This was unusual.
- This part of Mark describes Jesus being rejected by (3:7–6:6a):
 - his family (3:21, 31–35),
 - the scribes (3:22), and
 - the people of Gerasa (5:17).

It ends with rejection by people in his hometown (6:1–6a).

Along the way, a few people believed and Jesus healed them. This ending is similar to the end of the previous section (1:14–3:6).

Mark 6:6

This summary of the healing and preaching ministry of Jesus leads to a story about the disciples. Jesus likely taught from village to village near the Sea of Galilee, and perhaps in Capernaum (see 2:1).

Mark 6:6–8:21

The mission of Jesus and the misunderstanding of the disciples are prominent themes in this section.

Mark 6:7

- *two by two*: This practice fulfilled the Old Testament rule of needing two witnesses ([Numbers 35:30](#); [Deuteronomy 17:6](#); [19:15](#); see [Matthew 18:16](#)). It also allowed for them to have companionship and mutual help ([Acts 13:1–3](#); [15:22](#), [39](#), [40](#)).
- *giving them authority*: Jesus can give his authority to others (see [Mark 1:27](#); [2:10](#)).
- Jesus told the disciples to drive out *unclean spirits* and to preach and heal ([6:12–13](#); see [6:30](#)).

Mark 6:7–13

Jesus sent the disciples to preach and heal. During this mission, they memorized the teachings of Jesus by repeating them. This prepared them to later recall and share what Jesus did and taught ([Luke 1:2](#)).

Mark 6:8–9

The instructions for the disciples' mission focused on what they should leave behind (*bread ...bag ...money ... second tunic*). They were to travel with little and rely on Jewish kindness to strangers for food and a place to sleep at night (see [Luke 22:35–37](#)).

Mark 6:10

They were to sleep in the same house and not take advantage of kindness of their hosts by looking for better food and another place to sleep at night.

Mark 6:11

shake the dust off your feet: This represents God's judgment on those who rejected the apostles' message (see [Acts 18:6](#)). To reject it was actually to reject Jesus and God, who sent him ([9:37](#)).

Mark 6:12–13

The call to repent is a short form of the fuller message in [1:15](#).

Mark 6:14

- *Jesus' name had become well known*: The successful mission in Galilee and Perea by six teams of disciples helped spread news about him throughout the region ([6:12–13](#)).
- *John the Baptist has risen from the dead!*: King Herod may have thought that John the Baptist had come back to life and was now working through Jesus. This idea is similar to how Elijah's spirit came upon Elisha.

Or, he might have been expressing frustration, saying something like, "This is John the Baptist all over again!" (the same kind of powerful prophet has appeared again).

Mark 6:14–29

The story of John the Baptist's death, placed between the disciples' mission and return, emphasizes the authority and power of Jesus (see [6:7](#), [14](#)). John's end and the warning to the disciples during their mission also point ahead to the death of Jesus ([6:11](#)). The one greater even than John ([1:8](#)) would soon be handed over to religious and political leaders and put to death ([8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:33](#)).

Mark 6:15

The return of the prophet Elijah had been prophesied in [Malachi 3:1](#) and [4:5–6](#) (see also [Mark 9:11–13](#)).

Mark 6:17

- *that John be arrested and bound and imprisoned*: The Jewish historian Josephus (*Antiquities* 18.5.2) says that John was imprisoned in the fortress of Machaerus in Perea.
- Josephus (*Antiquities* 18.5.1–4) also mentions that Herodias was the wife of Herod Antipas's half-brother, Herod Philip.

Mark 6:18

- Mark explains the moral and religious reason for the arrest and execution of John the Baptist. The Jewish historian Josephus gives a political reason instead. He says Herod feared that John's popularity might lead to a rebellion (Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.5.2).

In a similar way, the charges against Jesus began as religious concerns ([Mark 14:63–64](#)). But when he was brought before Pontius Pilate, the charges became political ([15:2](#); [Luke 23:2–3](#)).

- *It is not lawful*: John said that Herod's marriage was wrong. It was adultery ([Leviticus 20:10](#)). It also broke the law that forbids a man from marrying his brother's wife ([Leviticus 18:16](#); [20:21](#)).

Mark 6:19–28

Herodias's role in John the Baptist's murder is similar to the story of Jezebel ([1 Kings 19:1–2](#)). Like Jezebel, she pushed for the death of a prophet.

Herod gave in to pressure ([Mark 6:26–28](#)). This points ahead to what Pontius Pilate later did. Pilate ordered that Jesus be put to death even though he believed Jesus was innocent (compare [6:20](#), [25–28](#) with [15:6–15](#)).

Mark 6:22

the daughter of Herodias: The first-century Jewish historian Josephus wrote that Herodias's daughter was also named Salome (Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.5.4).

Mark 6:29

This verse is similar to the description of the death and burial of Jesus (see 15:43–46). Disciples of John existed after his death until at least the AD 200s (see Acts 18:24–19:7).

Mark 6:30

- Mark refers to the disciples of Jesus as *apostles* to show their new role as those who had been sent out (see study note on 3:14–15). This also helps avoid confusion with John the Baptist's disciples.
- The apostles reported the success of what they had done and taught.

Mark 6:30–44

The disciples finish their mission (6:6–13, 30–34). Then the story of feeding the 5,000 follows (6:35–44; see also Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–15). The feeding of the 4,000 is different enough to show these were two separate events (see Mark 8:1–10).

Mark 6:31–33

- *Come with me:* Jesus and the disciples likely traveled north along the western shore of the Sea of Galilee toward Bethsaida (Luke 9:10). As they moved, the crowds could still see them along the shore.
- *many people:* The large crowds show the success of the apostles' mission and the greatness of Jesus, whom the apostles represented.

Mark 6:34

they were like sheep without a shepherd: God's people need guidance (Numbers 27:16–17; 1 Kings 22:17; 2 Chronicles 18:16; see Jeremiah 13:10; Ezekiel 34:23). In Jewish writings, teaching God's word is like feeding sheep (for example, Ezekiel 34:1–24; 2 Baruch 77:13–15).

Mark 6:35–36

The place where Jesus taught was remote (far from towns), but it still had farms and villages nearby where people could buy food.

Mark 6:37

Jesus suggests that, just as the disciples were able to drive out demons and heal through his power (6:7, 13, 30), they should be able to feed the crowd. Their reply shows that they were thinking only about what they could do on their own.

They did not take into account the power of Jesus (his ability to act with God's authority).

Mark 6:41

The words *taking*, *blessed*, *broke*, and *gave* reflect the words Jesus spoke at the Last Supper (14:22–25). Both events imagine the final messianic feast where Christians will eat and drink with Jesus in the kingdom of God (14:25; Matthew 5:6; 22:1–10; see Revelation 2:7; 19:7–9; 22:1–2, 14, 17–19).

Mark 6:42–44

This miracle makes Elisha's miracle of feeding 100 people with 20 loaves seem less impressive (2 Kings 4:42–44). We should ask ourselves, "Who is this?" (Mark 4:41). He is the Christ, the Son of God (1:1).

Mark 6:45–46

The disciples went to Bethsaida, the hometown of Peter and Andrew (John 1:44). Meanwhile, Jesus dismissed the crowd and went away by himself to pray.

Jesus regularly prayed (Mark 1:35). He also urged his disciples to pray (see 14:38).

Mark 6:45–52

This story shows the glory of Jesus (his divine power and greatness) to the disciples (6:48–50). It is also a rescue story, because Jesus comes to help them in danger (6:47–48, 51).

At the same time, it shows that the disciples did not understand what was happening (6:51–52).

Mark 6:48

- *About the fourth watch of the night:* This was about three o'clock in the morning. This Roman way of telling time suggests that Mark wrote for Christians in Rome.
- Mark does not explain how Jesus saw his disciples struggling in the middle of the lake at night. It is not important to the story.
- *Jesus went out to them, walking on the sea:* It seems Jesus came to rescue them from the storm. But Mark says that Jesus *intended to pass by them*. Many have tried to explain this, but perhaps the best explanation is that *to pass them by* refers to a divine appearance. This is similar to events in Exodus and 1 Kings, where divine glory is shown. The disciples' fear supports this idea, as fear often accompanies divine appearances.
- Many have tried to explain the miracle of Jesus walking on water. But Mark, Matthew, and John saw it as a miracle without a natural explanation. If Jesus is truly the Son of God, there needs to be no other explanation.

Mark 6:49–50

- The disciples were very afraid, and this reaction makes sense. People cannot walk on water, so they thought they were seeing a ghost.

As in many times when God appears (divine manifestations, when God shows himself), the Lord spoke words of comfort: “Take courage! It is I. Do not be afraid.”

It was not a ghost but Jesus (their friend, Savior, and Lord).

- *It is I*: Jesus walking on the sea and calming the storm were miracles (acts of God’s power). Because of this, Mark’s first audience would have understood the words *I am* as more than a simple statement. They would have heard a connection to how God describes himself in the Old Testament ([Exodus 3:14](#); [Deuteronomy 32:39](#); [Isaiah 41:4](#); [43:10–13](#)). This suggests that Jesus shares in God’s identity (he is divine).

Mark 6:51

- When Jesus got into the boat, the storm stopped.
- *utterly astounded*: The disciples were filled with awe and reverence (deep respect and wonder) at the greatness of Jesus Christ, the Son of God (compare [2:12](#); [5:24](#); [Matthew 14:33](#)).

Mark 6:52

The account ends with a comment about the disciples’ lack of understanding. This was not because they lacked the opportunity to believe in Jesus. They had seen the miracle of the loaves and many other miracles.

Instead, their hearts were too hard (they were not open to understanding). This is usually a quality of those who oppose Jesus (for example, [3:5](#); see also [8:17](#), [21](#); [9:32](#)).

Later, their hearts would be changed. They would come to understand these things ([Luke 24:44–49](#); [John 12:16](#); [13:7](#)).

Mark 6:53

Gennesaret was a fertile plain (good land for growing crops), about 5.6 kilometers long (3.5 miles) and 0.8 kilometers wide (0.5 miles). It lay between Tiberias and Capernaum on the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee.

The disciples first planned to go to Bethsaida ([6:45](#)). One possibility is that strong winds ([6:48](#)) pushed the boat off course, and they landed at Gennesaret instead. Another possibility is that [6:45](#) describes the direction of travel (toward the northeast), not the exact destination.

Mark 6:53–56

This short summary of the work Jesus did in Galilee shows how popular he was and how he healed many people.

Mark 6:56

the fringe of His cloak: This refers to the tassels that Jewish men wore on the edges of their robes (see [Numbers 15:38–39](#); [Deuteronomy 22:12](#)). Touching the *fringe of His cloak* brought healing to sick people (see also [Mark 3:10](#); [5:28](#)).

Mark 7:1

Mark’s audience already knows that the Pharisees and teachers of religious law were hostile to Jesus (see [2:16](#), [24](#); [3:6](#), [22](#)).

Mark 7:1–23

This account does not connect directly to what comes before it. It simply fits a general setting, such as “At one point in the ministry of Jesus.”

After Mark sets the scene ([7:1–4](#)), he introduces the Pharisees’ question ([7:5](#)). Then Jesus responds to the question ([6–23](#)).

The first part of the response focuses on two Old Testament passages ([7:6–13](#)). It also includes a two-part critique (strong criticism) of the Pharisees’ traditions ([7:6–8](#), [9–13](#)).

In the second part, Jesus explains what truly defiles a person (what makes someone unclean before God; [7:14–23](#)).

Mark 7:2–4

Mark explains the Pharisees’ practices of ritual cleansing (ceremonial washing for religious purity) for his non-Jewish (Gentile) audience.

The *traditions of the elders* were not yet written down at that time. The Pharisees believed these teachings had been given to Moses on Mount Sinai along with the written law.

These traditions were later written down around AD 200 in the *Mishnah* (a collection of Jewish teachings and laws). The Mishnah is one of the main sources for understanding ancient Judaism.

Mark 7:5

Since the Pharisees believed that their oral traditions were given to Moses as part of God’s divine revelation, they asked Jesus why his disciples did not keep them. After all, teachers were responsible for the behavior of their disciples (see [2:24](#)).

Mark 7:6–8

Jesus first responds by quoting [Isaiah 29:13](#) (from the Greek version). This passage speaks about the problem of treating human ideas as if they were God’s commands.

It describes well what was happening with the Pharisees. They had replaced God's law with their own traditions (human rules and teachings).

Mark 7:9–13

Next, Jesus gives an example where the Pharisees' traditions went against God's law. Their traditions allowed them to avoid what God's law required.

Mark 7:11–12

- *But you say:* The contrast with God's law is very strong. Their tradition went against God's command to honor parents by caring for their needs.
- *'Whatever you would have received from me is Corban' (that is, a gift devoted to God):* This tradition taught that people could avoid helping their parents. They could promise to give their resources to God instead. In this way, they ignored and dishonored their parents, even when their parents were in need.

Mark 7:13

- The result of such traditions was to cancel the word of God.
- *in many such matters:* This was not a unique instance (see, for example, [Isaiah 1:10–20](#) and [58:1–14](#)).

Mark 7:14–23

The second argument of Jesus against the Pharisees was a proverb he told the crowd. Later, in a private setting, Jesus explained it to his disciples ([7:17–23](#)). It concerns moral distinctions about eating (rules about what is right or wrong to eat). Eating affects the system that processes food, but moral issues involve the heart. The heart is a metaphor for where a person makes moral decisions.

How a person eats (with ceremonially clean or unclean hands) or what a person eats (ceremonially clean or unclean food) only affects the system that processes food. So it does not impact the moral issues of the human soul or inner being. To help his later audience understand the meaning of this teaching, Mark adds this comment *Thus all foods are clean*.

In the early church, Peter and Paul helped make this meaning clear (see [Acts 10:1–11:18](#); [Romans 14:14](#); [1 Corinthians 8:8](#); [Galatians 2:11–21](#)).

Mark 7:20–22

These verses list 13 things that truly make a person unclean (morally impure). These actions and wrong desires come from the heart (a person's inner thoughts and intentions).

Mark 7:24

- The city of Tyre and its nearby areas are on the Mediterranean coast in modern Lebanon. Tyre was originally an island but became a peninsula when Alexander the Great built a half-mile ramp from the shore in 332 BC.

Tyre had one of the most important harbors on the eastern Mediterranean Sea. People from Tyre had previously come to hear Jesus and see his miracles ([3:7–8](#)). This explains how the woman from Tyre knew about him.

- There is much discussion about why Jesus left Galilee to visit this Gentile (non-Jewish) region. Mark does not explain the reason, so any suggestion is only a guess.

However, Mark's Gentile audience would have understood this journey as pointing ahead to the church's mission to the Gentile world. This mission later led to their own coming to faith (for more about how the church began in Rome, see [Romans Book Introduction](#)).

Mark 7:24–30

The discussion of clean and unclean and of undefiled and defiled in [7:1–23](#) has prepared Mark's audience for the story of the Gentile woman's faith. Jews considered Gentiles to be defiled because they did not keep the regulations of the Torah (see [Acts 10:1–11:18](#), especially [10:14–15](#); [11:2–3, 8–9](#)).

Mark 7:25–26

The woman was from Syrian Phoenicia and therefore a Gentile. The urgency and intensity of the woman's petition is seen in her falling at the feet of Jesus and begging.

Mark 7:27–28

- Jesus responds to the woman in what might seem like a severe way. But their interaction shows that Jesus wanted to see her faith (compare [Matthew 15:28](#)).
- Jesus did not use the word *first* to exclude her as a Gentile (non-Jew) from God's grace (kindness and favor). Instead, it showed that his mission was directed first to the Jews ([Acts 13:46](#); [Romans 1:16](#)).

The woman replied with humility and faith. She acknowledged the priority of the Jewish people but argued that there was more than enough food for the dogs as well.

Jewish writings often referred to Gentiles as dogs. Dogs were seen as dirty scavengers rather than family pets (see also study note on [Revelation 22:15](#)).

The woman's persistence and acknowledgment of Jesus as Lord were rewarded.

Mark 7:29–30

For similar healings from a distance, see [Matthew 8:5–13](#), [Luke 7:1–10](#), and [John 4:46–54](#).

Mark 7:31–37

- This miracle is very similar in order and wording to the healing of the blind man in [8:22–26](#). Healing miracles in the Gospels often follow a similar pattern. As these stories were told and retold, their form and wording likely became more consistent.
- This miracle also includes a change of location. Some think the next miracle happened in a Gentile area such as Sidon or the Decapolis. However, it is more likely that it took place after Jesus returned to the Sea of Galilee. The next event clearly happens there ([8:10](#)), with no change in location mentioned.

Mark 7:33

- The healing was done in private ([7:33](#); see [5:40–43](#); [8:23](#)). This likely helped prevent people from spreading strong excitement about Jesus as the Messiah (God’s chosen king; see [3:11–12](#); compare [John 6:15](#)).
- Jesus also used saliva in another healing ([Mark 8:23](#)), when he put it on a man’s eyes to heal his blindness. The use of saliva for healing was common in the ancient world. People believed it could help heal certain conditions.

Mark 7:34

- *And looking up to heaven, He sighed deeply*: Since Jesus was looking up to heaven when he sighed, his sigh is probably best understood as a prayerful gesture.
- *Ephphatha* is an Aramaic word that Mark translates for his audience (see also [3:17](#); [5:41](#); [14:36](#); [15:34](#)). These are not magical words. Mark is simply sharing some of the original words Jesus spoke.

Matthew and Luke do not seem to have attributed any special importance to the Aramaic words of Jesus, since they did not include them in their Gospels.

Mark 7:36–37

Even though Jesus tried to avoid attention, his greatness could not be hidden. His character, his teaching, and his power to heal filled people with awe (deep wonder and respect).

Mark 8:1–3

The last mention of a large crowd was during the feeding of the 5,000 ([6:34](#)). Jesus showed compassion in [6:34](#) because the people were “like sheep without a shepherd.”

These stories show the concern Jesus has for the whole person. Here, he especially focuses on their hunger. They were in the wilderness and had no food ([8:1,4](#)). They had been with Jesus for three days without food and had traveled a long way ([8:2](#)). They needed to eat before going home ([8:3](#)).

Mark 8:1–10

The stories about feeding the 4,000 and the 5,000 are similar. All four Gospels report the earlier feeding of the 5,000 ([6:35–44](#); [Matthew 14:13–21](#); [Luke 9:10–17](#); [John 6:1–15](#)). Only Mark and Matthew also record the feeding of the 4,000 as a separate miracle ([Matthew 15:32–39](#); [Mark 8:19–21](#); [Matthew 16:9–10](#)). The details of the events are different.

Mark 8:4

The disciples’ question shows their lack of understanding. They knew God provided manna in the wilderness during the time of Moses ([Exodus 16](#)). They were now with someone much greater than Moses (see [Mark 9:5–7](#)). They had recently seen him feed more people in a similar situation ([6:30–44](#)).

But they still did not understand (compare [6:52](#)). Even so, Jesus used them to provide physical and spiritual food to the hungry ([8:6–8](#)). What they could not do alone, the powerful Son of God did through them.

Mark 8:5

Seven: Many people have tried to find symbolic meaning in the numbers in the two feeding miracles. However, there is no agreement among these interpretations. The mention of “a few fish” in this story also suggests that the numbers are not symbolic.

None of the Gospel writers explain any special meaning for these numbers. This should caution us not to assign meaning to them.

As with the feeding of the five thousand, the numbers mainly serve to highlight the greatness of the miracle and of Jesus.

Mark 8:6–7

took ... gave thanks ... distributed: These terms describe the actions of Jesus during this event. These same actions appear later the Last Supper (compare [14:22–25](#)).

Mark 8:8

They ate as much as they wanted. Having plenty of food shows the greatness of God’s kingdom and the one who brought it.

Mark 8:10–13

- Like the earlier miracle where Jesus fed 5,000 people (6:30–44), after feeding 4,000 people, Jesus traveled across the Sea of Galilee by boat (compare 6:45). When he arrived, the Pharisees came to argue with him. They demanded that Jesus show them a miracle as proof (compare 7:1–23).
- We do not know where Dalmanutha was located. [Matthew 15:39](#) uses the name *Magadan* instead of *Dalmanutha* when describing this place.

Mark 8:11

The Pharisees continued to oppose Jesus (2:16–18, 24; 3:6; 7:1–5; 10:2; 12:13, 15). Their hostility did not stop.

Sometimes, asking for a sign is acceptable ([Judges 6:36–40](#); [2 Kings 20:8–11](#); [Isaiah 7:10–12](#); see also [John 2:18–19](#)). But in this case, their request was not sincere. It was a stubborn test of God (they were trying to challenge or trap him).

They were not asking for the kinds of signs Jesus had already done, such as healings, driving out demons (evil spirits), raising the dead, or controlling nature. Many of these had already happened, and people widely knew about them ([Mark 1:32–34](#), 45; 3:7–12; 6:53–56). Even the Pharisees knew about them (3:22).

Instead, they wanted a sign from heaven (that is, a direct sign from God) to prove once for all that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen king). But no sign would have convinced them.

For those who were open to the truth, the miracles Jesus had already done were clear signs that he is the Messiah, the Son of God ([Luke 7:22](#)). But for those who were not open, no sign would lead them to believe ([Mark 4:11–12](#); compare [Luke 6:19–31](#)).

Mark 8:12

- *Truly I tell you*: This response is very strong. It is like an oath (a serious promise) and means something like, “[May God judge me] if I give this generation any such sign.” Such statements show firm and unchanging commitment (see [Genesis 14:22–23](#); [Numbers 32:10–11](#); [Ruth 1:17](#); [1 Samuel 3:17](#); 20:13; [2 Samuel 3:35](#); 19:13).
- Elsewhere, Jesus describes this generation as “adulterous and sinful” in [Mark 8:38](#) and “unbelieving” in 9:19.

Mark 8:14

The mention of having only *one loaf* of bread reminds Mark's audience of earlier times when the disciples did not have enough food. On those occasions, Jesus miraculously provided enough bread to feed thousands of people.

Mark 8:14–21

This story of the journey across the Sea of Galilee reflects on the greatness of Jesus, shown in the two feeding miracles. It also emphasizes the disciples' lack of understanding.

They do not see, hear, or understand because their hearts are hardened (not open to learning; see 4:9–20; 6:52).

Mark 8:15

Matthew says that *the leaven of the Pharisees* refers to their false teaching ([Matthew 16:12](#)). It might also refer to their unbelief and stubbornness ([Mark 8:10–13](#)).

The reference to Herod could suggest he was unwilling to accept what he knew to be true (6:14, 16, 20).

Mark 8:16

The disciples completely missed the meaning of the warning given by Jesus (8:15). They forgot that, because Jesus was with them, their lack of bread did not matter.

Mark 8:17–20

Jesus asked eight questions that rebuked the disciples. They, of all people, should have been aware of the miraculous power of the Son of God. Although the disciples still remembered the feeding miracles, they did not apply their meaning to the situation they were facing.

Mark 8:19–20

The questions of Jesus clearly recalled the feeding miracles (6:30–44; 8:1–10). He asked the disciples how many baskets of leftovers they had gathered after each event. By asking these questions, Jesus reminded them of what had already happened.

Mark 8:21

Do you still not understand?: This question suggests there will be a future time when they will truly understand. Mark's audience knew that the resurrection of Jesus would help the disciples understand the identity and power of Jesus (see, for example, [Acts 4:23–31](#)).

Mark 8:22–26

- Earlier, Jesus and the disciples tried to go to Bethsaida but did not succeed (6:45). Here, they arrive, and Jesus heals a blind man. Only Mark describes this two-part healing. It might connect to how the disciples came to a new spiritual understanding in the next story (8:27–38).
- [John 1:44](#) says Bethsaida is the home of Peter, Andrew, James, and John (see also [John 12:21](#)). This small fishing village was officially part of Gaulanitis. But people usually considered it part of Galilee ([John 12:21](#)). It was relocated

and given status as a city by Philip the Tetrarch (Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.2.1).

Mark 8:23

He spit on the man's eyes (see 7:33; compare with John 9:6–7): We do not know exactly what eye problem the man had. Any attempt to identify it is only a guess and can distract from the miracle.

Mark 8:24–25

The healing was not immediate. At first, the man saw imperfectly. After Jesus touched him a second time, he fully healed the man.

Who is this man who calms the sea and heals the blind? Peter reveals this in the next account. He is the Christ (8:29).

Mark 8:26

The story ends with Jesus telling the healed man to keep the event a secret (see 3:11–12).

Mark 8:27–28

- Philip the Tetrarch (a regional ruler) was the son of Herod the Great. Philip built Caesarea Philippi on the slopes of Mount Hermon, about 40 kilometers (25 miles) north of the Sea of Galilee. The more famous Caesarea on the coast was built by his father.
- *Who do people say I am?*: As a good teacher, Jesus asked this question to understand what his disciples thought. Their answer is similar to 6:14–16.
- *John the Baptist*: See study note on 6:14.
- *one of the prophets*: Many people saw Jesus as a prophet (a person who speaks for God; see 6:4; 14:65; Luke 7:16, 39; 13:33; 24:19).

Mark 8:27–38

Peter's declaration that Jesus is the Christ (the Messiah, God's chosen king) and the first prediction of his death mark a turning point in the Gospel of Mark. This begins a new stage in his ministry. The question, "Who is this?" asked by the disciples in 4:41, is now answered by Peter.

Mark 8:27–9.1

This section is the first cycle (a repeated pattern) that includes three parts:

- Jesus predicts his suffering (8:31),
- the disciples respond with misunderstanding (8:32–33), and
- Jesus teaches about discipleship (what it means to follow him; 8:34–9.1).

Compare with 9:30–10:31.

Mark 8:29–30

But who do you say I am? In the Greek text, *you* is emphatic. Peter responded for the group, You are the Messiah. Peter's confession was correct, as the command not to tell anyone about him indicates (see 3:11–12; see also 1:1; 14:61–62; Matt 16:17).

Mark 8:31

It was a divine necessity that Jesus must suffer (see also 9:11; 13:7, 10). The immediate cause for Jesus' suffering was the elders, the leading priests, and the teachers of religious law (see 10:33; 11:18, 27; 14:1, 43, 53), but the ultimate cause was the will of God. • Jesus' death would not be the end, for three days later he would rise from the dead. • Three days later is a synonym for *on the third day* (Matt 16:21; Luke 9:22) and *after three days and three nights* (Matt 12:40).

Mark 8:31–38

Then Jesus began to teach the disciples that he would suffer and be killed in Jerusalem and three days later . . . rise from the dead. Jesus now explicitly predicted what he had revealed in veiled form (2:19–20). In response, Peter objected, so Jesus taught him and the other disciples the nature of his mission and what it really means to follow him.

Mark 8:32

Peter understood what Jesus had said, but he did not accept it. Peter shared the popular idea that the Messiah was to be a victorious national ruler, so he thought Jesus' talk of suffering and death was nonsense.

Mark 8:33

Jesus looked at his disciples before he publicly rebuked Peter; he wanted them to understand that Peter was wrong. • Get away from me, Satan does not mean that Peter was demon-possessed. Peter spoke from a human point of view, not from God's, so he unwittingly spoke for Satan, the god of this world (2 Cor 4:4), and repeated Satan's temptation (cp. Matt 4:8–10).

Mark 8:34–38

Jesus' invitation to his disciples and the crowd lays out the cost of being his follower. • To give up your own way involves letting Jesus determine your goals and purposes in life. To take up your cross is metaphorical (cp. Luke 9:23); it indicates that faithfulness to Jesus must extend, if required, even to the point of death. To follow Jesus' teaching and example is a continual commitment.

Mark 8:35

If you try to hang on to (literally *save*) your life by keeping it from Jesus, you will lose it in the next world. But if you lose it to Jesus and his cause (the spread of the Good News), you will save it forever.

Mark 8:36–37

The implied answer to Jesus' rhetorical question is that possessing the entire world has no value if you give up eternal life. "He is no fool who gives what he cannot keep to gain that which he cannot lose" (Jim Elliot). You need your soul to enjoy the benefits of the world to come. When you forfeit your life or soul, there is nothing you can give to purchase it back.

Mark 8:38

When Jesus, as the Son of Man, returns in glory to judge the world, he will be ashamed of those who were ashamed to be identified with him and his message (cp. [Matt 7:21–23](#); [10:32–33](#); [Luke 12:8–9](#); [2 Tim 2:12](#)).

Mark 9:1

The introductory I tell you the truth indicates that the promise in this verse is important, but the meaning of the promise is much debated. It might suggest that some of the disciples will (1) witness Jesus' resurrection from the dead (ch 16); (2) experience the coming of the Spirit upon the church ([Acts 2](#)); (3) see the fall of Jerusalem in AD 70; or (4) witness Jesus' transfiguration as a foretaste of God's coming Kingdom. Mark's placement of the promise right before the transfiguration account ([Mark 9:2–8](#)) indicates that he probably meant the transfiguration as the fulfillment (see [2 Pet 1:16–18](#)).

Mark 9:2–8

This account is tied to [8:27–9:1](#) both chronologically (six days later) and thematically ([9:7](#)). • The presence of Peter, James, and John (see also [5:37](#); [13:3](#); [14:33](#)) might be the fulfillment of [9:1](#) ("some standing here"). Some interpreters believe that the pre-incarnate glory of the Son of God broke through the veil of his humanity ([John 1:14](#); [17:5](#)) at the transfiguration. It is more likely that this event was an advance glimpse of the Son of Man's future glory (see [Matt 16:28](#); [2 Pet 1:16–18](#); cp. [Exod 34:28–35](#); [2 Cor 3:7–18](#)).

Mark 9:4

The appearance of Elijah and Moses might indicate the fulfillment of the law and the prophets in Jesus (see [Matthew 5:17](#); compare [Malachi 4:4–5](#)).

Mark 9:5–6

The idea to *put up three shelters* as memorials treats Moses, Elijah, and Jesus as equals (see [Leviticus 23:33–43](#); [Numbers 29:12–34](#)). But this idea ignored Peter's earlier confession that Jesus is the Messiah ([Mark 8:29](#)). It also ignored that only Jesus had been transfigured (his appearance changed and showed his glory, [9:2–3](#)).

Mark 9:7

a cloud: Cp. [Exod 40:34–35](#). • The voice from the cloud issued a stern rebuke of Peter's suggestion: This is my dearly loved Son—not an equal of Moses and Elijah. God's voice also confirmed Peter's earlier confession ([Mark 8:29](#)), and it indirectly rebuked Peter for rejecting Jesus' prediction of his suffering ([8:32](#)) by telling him and the other disciples to listen to him.

Mark 9:8

Only Jesus remained, not Moses or Elijah. Jesus was clearly superior to Elijah and Moses.

Mark 9:9

Secrecy would no longer be necessary after the Son of Man had risen from the dead, because Jesus the Messiah would then be clearly understood as apolitical and non-militaristic, so he could be proclaimed openly to all (see [Acts 2:36](#); [3:6](#)).

Mark 9:10

The three disciples only understood what Jesus meant by *rise from the dead* after it happened.

Mark 9:11

The disciples wanted to understand the prediction that Elijah must return before the Messiah comes (see [Mal 4:5–6](#)). How did this prediction fit with Jesus' proclamation of God's Kingdom and his prediction of his own death, resurrection, and return ([Mark 8:31](#), [38](#); [9:9](#))?

Mark 9:12

The teachers of the law were correct: Elijah must return before the consummation of God's Kingdom, but Scripture also said that the Son of Man would suffer greatly (e.g., [Ps 22](#); [Isa 52:13–53:12](#)).

Mark 9:13

The teachers of the law erred by not realizing that Elijah had already come (see [Matt 17:11–13](#); cp. [Mal 4:5–6](#)). As a result, they failed to recognize that the Kingdom of God had already come and that the Messiah's suffering and death that were predicted in Scripture were about to take place.

Mark 9:14

Jesus and the three disciples (Peter, James, and John) rejoined the other disciples, the crowd, and the teachers of the law. This account is similar to the story of Moses descending from Mount Sinai to rejoin the people of Israel ([Exod 34:29–35](#)).

Mark 9:14–29

This is the fourth and last exorcism in Mark ([1:21–28](#); [5:1–20](#); [7:24–30](#)). The disciples were unable to perform the exorcism, so Jesus performed it, emphasizing the necessity of faith (cp. [2:5](#); [5:34](#); [10:52](#)). This is another example of Jesus' great healing ability and of the disciples' failure ([8:32–33](#); [9:5–7](#)).

Mark 9:15

Some have suggested that just as Moses reflected God's glory when he descended from the mountain, Jesus' glorious transfiguration was still evident, so the crowds responded with awe. It is equally possible that Jesus' arrival after being absent was enough to elicit the awe of the crowd.

Mark 9:18

These symptoms are often associated with epilepsy (see [Matt 17:15](#)), but Mark emphasizes the demonic origin of the child's problem ([Mark 9:17–18](#), [25–26](#), [28](#)). The disciples' inability to heal the child magnifies the effect of Jesus' power ([9:25–26](#)).

Mark 9:19

Jesus said to them: Jesus might have been speaking to the disciples, the father ([9:22–24](#)), the crowd, or all present.

- How long? Their lack of faith was obstinate and hard-hearted (cp. [3:5](#); [6:52](#); [8:17](#); [10:5](#)).

Mark 9:20

The demon did not speak (compare [1:24](#); [5:7](#), [9–10](#); see also [1:34](#); [3:11–12](#)). Instead, it acted violently, just as the father had described ([9:18](#)).

Mark 9:21–22

- The demon's activity had been taking place since he was a little boy, and the demon had tried to kill the child in various ways.
- *If You can*: The father's request shows that his faith had become weak ([9:18](#)).

Mark 9:23

Jesus urged the man to trust in the power of God. Anything is possible if a person believes (see [11:22–24](#)). But a lack of faith can limit how people receive God's saving work (see [6:5](#)).

Mark 9:24

In desperation, the father cried out that he believed, though weakly.

Mark 9:25

The crowd was approaching, so Jesus quickly proceeded with the exorcism. • The I in the command to the demon is emphatic, dramatizing Jesus' authority and power. • never enter him again! At times exorcisms could be temporary (see [Matt 12:43–45](#); [Luke 11:24–26](#)).

Mark 9:26–27

The demon reacted with great force. This showed how powerful the demon was and how much greater Jesus was (compare [1:25–26](#); [5:15](#)).

Mark 9:28–29

The story ends in an unexpected way. It emphasizes the importance of prayer more than the importance of faith (compare [11:22–24](#)).

Mark 9:30–10.31

This section is the second cycle (see study note on [8:27–9:1](#)) containing:

- a prediction about the suffering of Jesus ([9:30–32](#)),
- an error by the disciples ([9:33–34](#)), and
- teaching about discipleship ([9:35–10:31](#)).

Mark 9:31

- Jesus continued to seek privacy to teach the disciples about his future suffering (see [7:24](#)).
- *The Son of Man will be delivered*: See [14:10–11](#), [41–45](#).

Mark 9:32

The disciples were still unable to accept the teaching of Jesus concerning his death or to recognize how it fit into God's plan.

Mark 9:33–34

- Capernaum was where Jesus lived in Galilee ([1:21](#); [2:1](#)).
- The disciples of Jesus did not answer his question because they knew he would not approve of their discussion.
- *arguing about which of them was the greatest*: This issue would come up again in [10:35–37](#).

Mark 9:33–50

The disciples did not understand the prediction Jesus made about his suffering. Because of this, they could not see what it meant for their own lives.

Mark 9:35

Sitting down: Jesus sat down and took the role of a teacher (see 4:1–2; 12:41; [Matthew 5:1](#); [Luke 4:20](#); 5:3).

True greatness in the kingdom of God means serving others, not ruling over them. Jesus showed this by his own example ([Mark 10:45](#)).

Mark 9:36–37

In the time of Jesus, people did not view children as especially innocent or pure. Instead, they saw them as weak and of low status. Jesus said that people should receive a child in his name (that is, as his representative).

Welcoming a child shows humility. It means choosing a low place and serving others (9:35; see also [10:13–16](#)). Other teachings of Jesus show that how people receive or reject his followers is the same as how they receive or reject him ([Matthew 10:40](#); [25:31–46](#); [Luke 10:16](#); [John 13:20](#)).

Mark 9:38–41

An unknown exorcist was casting out demons in Jesus' name though he was not one of the twelve disciples (9:38–40). John objected, but Jesus corrected him. • we told him to stop: Cp. [10:35–43](#); [Luke 9:51–55](#). • The success of the unknown exorcist is contrasted with the failure of the disciples in the previous account ([Mark 9:14–29](#)).

Mark 9:40

The negative parallel to this proverb is found in [Luke 11:23](#). These two proverbs should be understood as complementary, not contradictory, for Luke includes them both ([Luke 9:50](#); [11:23](#)). The exorcist casting out demons in Jesus' name was not against Jesus, but for him.

Mark 9:42–50

if you cause . . . sin: The consequences of causing sin ties these verses together (9:42–43, 45, 47). These sayings were not meant to be interpreted literally, for carrying them out would not prevent sin (see [Matt 15:10–20](#)). What Jesus conveys by these warnings is that no sin is worth going to hell for. It is better to repent—even if repenting is as painful as cutting off a hand, foot, or eye—than to suffer the punishment of hell.

Mark 9:43

hell: Greek *Gehenna*, referring to the Valley of Hinnom, which bordered Jerusalem on the southwest. It was a garbage dump for the city, and the continual burning of refuse there became a metaphor for the final place of judgment for the wicked.

Mark 9:43–48

Most of the best manuscripts do not include 9:44, 46, but a few include them. These two verses were almost certainly copied from 9:48 and were not in the original text of Mark.

Mark 9:48

The eternity of hell is emphasized by the phrases never die and never goes out (cp. 9:43). The horror of hell is emphasized by its portrayal as a place of everlasting fire, and of decay and corruption where maggots eternally eat everything away. The putrid smell of decay and the presence of maggots in the Valley of Hinnom may lie behind this imagery (see study note on 9:43). This imagery is a powerful warning for people to repent in order to escape the punishment of hell.

Mark 9:49–50

tested with fire: Literally *salted with fire*. The fire of testing has a purifying effect, like salt (see also [1 Pet 1:7](#); [4:12](#); [Rev 3:18](#)). Salt also refers to Christian character. Genuine Christian character will have a genuinely purifying influence. • But if it loses its flavor: The salt mined from the Dead Sea often contained gypsum, so although it looked like perfectly good salt, it was useless. It did not taste salty, and it created a disposal problem.

Mark 10:1–2

The Pharisees' question about divorce was much debated in Judaism, but it had a hostile purpose as they tried to trap Jesus (see [2:16](#), [18](#), [24](#); [7:5](#); [8:11](#); [12:13](#)). John the Baptist was beheaded over his teaching that Herod Antipas's divorce and remarriage was unlawful ([6:18–19](#)), and according to the Jewish historian Josephus, John was martyred close to Jesus' current location east of the Jordan River, at Herod Antipas's fortress at Machaerus (see [6:28](#); Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.5.2). If Jesus answered in agreement with John the Baptist, the Pharisees could indict him before Herod. But if Jesus said that divorce was lawful, he would be contradicting a prophet.

Mark 10:3

Jesus answered the trick question of the Pharisees with a counter-question. Instead of replying directly, he asked them a question in return (see [Matthew 22:20](#)).

Mark 10:4

The Pharisees quoted what Moses permitted. There was much debate among rabbis as to what constituted the "something wrong" (see [Deut 24:1](#)) that made divorce permissible. Rabbi Shammai allowed divorce only on the basis of sexual immorality. Rabbi Hillel permitted divorce even if a woman

burned her husband's dinner or was less attractive than someone else (*Mishnah Gittin* 9:10).

Mark 10:5–9

God permitted divorce as a concession to the hard hearts of the people. But God's will is more aptly expressed in the passages that Jesus quotes from the law of Moses ([Gen 1:27; 2:23–24](#); see also [Mal 2:16](#)). Jesus shows that God delights in marriage, which is the creation of a new union in which two become one. No one should rebel against God's will by seeking to split apart what God has united.

Mark 10:10

Jesus often explained his teaching to his disciples in the privacy of a house (see [7:17](#); [9:28, 33](#)).

Mark 10:11–12

Whoever divorces . . . and marries someone else commits adultery: The parallel in [Luke 16:18](#) agrees with Mark and mentions no exceptions to this prohibition of divorce, while Matthew's parallel account allows an exception in cases of infidelity ([Matt 19:9](#); see also [Matt 5:32](#)). Paul also allows an exception if an unbelieving partner deserts the marriage ([1 Cor 7:15](#)). Mark's account focuses on the core principles—God hates divorce ([Mal 2:16](#)), marriage is meant to be for life, and divorce betrays the divine purpose of marriage.

Mark 10:13

The ages of the children cannot be determined from this passage. The Greek word *paidia* can refer to a broad spectrum of ages, from a twelve-year-old child ([5:41–42](#)) down to an eight-day-old infant ([Gen 17:12](#), Greek version). • the disciples scolded the parents: See study note on [Luke 18:15–17](#).

Mark 10:13–16

Jesus' love and concern for children has already been seen in [5:41–43](#); [9:36–37, 42](#). Jesus uses the incident to teach that the Kingdom of God belongs to those who are like these children.

Mark 10:14–15

Mark does not explain what characteristics of children make them fit for the Kingdom of God; [Matthew 18:4–5](#) suggests that the attributes include humility and the ability to receive things simply.

Mark 10:17

The rich man ([10:22](#)) was a young ruler ([Matt 19:20](#); [Luke 18:18](#)) who showed respect toward Jesus by kneeling and calling Jesus Good Teacher. *Teacher* is a frequent title for

Jesus in Mark (see [Mark 4:38](#); [5:35](#); [9:17, 38](#); [10:20, 35](#); [12:14, 19, 32](#); [13:1](#); [14:14](#)); the addition of *good* is unique.

Mark 10:17–31

The story of the rich man continues the themes of discipleship begun in [9:33](#) and the requirements for entering the Kingdom of God ([10:13–16](#)). The attitude of the rich man contrasts sharply with the childlike faith necessary for entering the Kingdom of God.

Mark 10:18

Jesus' reply has troubled interpreters for centuries. Jesus was probably objecting to the man's loose application of the term *good* to any human being, since ultimate goodness and perfection belong to God alone. Without in any way denying his own goodness, Jesus wanted to focus the rich man's attention on God. The rich man wanted to enter the Kingdom of God, and Jesus was contrasting God's goodness with the man's own human sinfulness.

Mark 10:19

Jesus' reply seems strange to Christians who are familiar with Paul's teaching on this subject (e.g., [Rom 3:20](#); [Gal 2:16](#)). In naming five of the Ten Commandments Jesus was not implying that the man could earn eternal life by keeping them; he was telling him what God's standards are and allowing the man to evaluate his own performance. Truly loving God with all one's heart, soul, mind, and strength, and one's neighbor as one's self ([Mark 12:30–31](#)), requires trusting in God's grace, accepting Jesus' sacrificial death on our behalf ([10:45](#); [14:24](#)), and keeping his commands ([John 15:10](#); [1 Jn 2:4](#); [3:22](#)).

Mark 10:20

The man's reply was naive (as to what it really means to keep these commands; see [Matt 5:21–48](#)), but it was not arrogant, as the lack of any rebuke indicates (cp. [Mark 12:13–17](#); [Matt 23:1–36](#)).

Mark 10:21

Instead of having an extended discussion about what it means to truly keep the commandments, Jesus focused on the specific issue that revealed this man's problem. He still lacked one thing: He loved riches more than he loved God, thus breaking the first and most important commandment ([12:29–30](#); [Exod 20:3](#); [Deut 6:5](#)). Entering the Kingdom of God requires repentance ([Mark 1:15](#); [6:12](#)), and Jesus helped this man to understand exactly what repentance entailed for him. He did not need, as he might have thought, to attain a higher level of personal righteousness. He needed to enter God's Kingdom through repentance and wholehearted love for God, thereby obtaining eternal life. He must deny

himself (8:34) and love God first and foremost by giving away his money. For other commands involving a negative [sell all] and a positive [follow me] element, see 1:15, 18, 20; 10:28; see also Acts 2:38; 20:21. • Jesus' command to the rich man was not a universal requirement for entering the Kingdom of God but was addressed to his particular situation. It teaches anyone seeking eternal life that nothing else can come before God; repentance (Mark 1:15; 6:12) requires the removal of anything that we place above God.

Mark 10:22

Mark records the rich man's tragic choice. The man departed, still possessing his earthly riches (Matt 6:19) but lacking eternal treasure (Matt 13:44–46). His demeanor (face fell . . . sad) showed his awareness that his awful choice had brought him sorrow rather than joy.

Mark 10:23–27

Jesus surprised the disciples by challenging the common belief that wealth was a sign of God's favor.

Mark 10:24

When the disciples were amazed, Jesus spoke to them with care and called them *children*.

Mark 10:25

Jesus was emphatically warning that riches are an obstacle to entering the Kingdom of God. The camel was the largest animal in Palestine, the eye of a needle the smallest hole. Some rich people are evidently able to overcome the problem created by riches and follow Jesus, but Jesus' followers came from among the poor more than from the rich. • Explanations about a gate in the Jerusalem wall called the "Eye of the Needle" are ill-conceived. There never was such a gate, and this explanation loses sight of Jesus' frequent use of hyperbole in his teaching (see also Matt 7:3–5; 23:24).

Mark 10:26

The disciples were astounded: It was generally believed that wealth was a sign of God's blessing that enabled the rich to do good deeds. Accordingly, it was assumed that the rich had an inside track on entering the Kingdom of God. The disciples' question was natural, given this understanding. God's assessment was the opposite of their conventional wisdom.

Mark 10:27

This verse tends to be interpreted in one of two ways: (1) Although salvation by one's own effort is impossible, by God's grace people can be saved through faith (Eph 2:8–10). (2) God can give an unusual grace that enables people to

overcome their sinful love of riches and believe. Mark does not explain his understanding.

Mark 10:28

The disciples had done what Jesus told the rich man to do. They had given up everything to follow Jesus (1:16–20; 8:34–38).

Mark 10:29–30

Jesus assured his disciples that they would receive whatever they had given up for him many times over, including a new family in Christ (brothers, sisters, mothers, children) and Christian hospitality (houses). • a hundred times: What is gained in following Jesus far outweighs any loss. And in the world to come they will inherit the eternal life that the rich man desired but did not receive.

Mark 10:31

But many . . . greatest then: The account ends with a proverb, contrasting the way that God understands life and how people generally understand it (for similar sayings, see Matt 20:16; Luke 13:30). For those with eyes to see and ears to hear (Mark 4:9–12; 8:18), the Kingdom of God has already come, and the overturning of this world's values has begun.

Mark 10:32–34

The disciples' awe and the people's fear cast a dark shadow over what lay ahead, given the hostility of the Jerusalem leaders toward Jesus (see 3:22–30; 7:1–13). Taking the disciples aside again, Jesus described the coming events in the greatest detail yet (see also 8:31; 9:31). He knew what was about to happen; what awaited him in Jerusalem was neither a tragedy nor fate, but God's will (see 8:31–33; Acts 4:27–28). As the Son of God, Jesus had unique knowledge of his upcoming unique death as the Savior of the world.

Mark 10:33

The leading priests and the teachers of religious law were the human agents who fulfilled God's purpose through their hatred of Jesus. • They did not have the right of capital punishment (John 18:31), so they had to hand Jesus over to the Romans to carry out the actual execution.

Mark 10:35–45

Following Jesus' third prediction of his suffering (10:32–33) comes another example of the disciples' failure (see 8:31–33; 9:31–34). The first part of the account involves the foolish request of James and John (10:35–37) and Jesus' reply to them (10:38–40). Then Jesus explains to the other disciples what greatness and leadership in the Kingdom of God mean

(10:41–44). Jesus’ own supreme example of servanthood (10:45) illustrates and concludes this account.

Mark 10:37

The brothers’ request indicates that James and John correctly understood that Jesus was the Messiah (see 8:29; 9:2–8). However, they completely misunderstood what it meant to be a leader in God’s Kingdom (10:41–45).

Mark 10:38

The two brothers didn’t know what they were asking: To share in his glory, they must share in his suffering as servants. • to drink from the bitter cup: Drinking from a cup is often associated with suffering and death (Ps 75:8; Isa 51:17, 22; Jer 25:15; 49:12; Lam 4:21; see also Mark 14:24, 36). • The baptism of suffering recalls Jesus’ total commitment to God’s calling at his baptism, and it speaks of the believer’s own baptism into Jesus’ death, burial, and resurrection (Rom 6:3–5; Col 2:12).

Mark 10:39

James and John did indeed drink a bitter cup . . . of suffering for Jesus. James died for his faith (Acts 12:1–5). John died an old man, having experienced persecution (Tertullian, *The Soul* 50; Jerome, *Commentary on Galatians* 6, 10). Yet the death of James and John was not the same as that of Jesus—no believer can die Jesus’ death as a vicarious sacrifice for the sins of the world (Mark 10:45) or experience the divine wrath as he did (15:34).

Mark 10:40

Jesus did not grant their request. These places belong to those for whom God the Father has prepared them (see also 13:32).

Mark 10:41

the ten . . . became indignant: Perhaps they wanted the special places requested by James and John for themselves. All of the disciples needed a new understanding of what leadership in God’s kingdom means (10:42–45).

Mark 10:42–44

the rulers of the Gentiles: The unbelieving world (the rulers in this world) thinks that leadership means dominating others. Just as the role of Jesus as Messiah and Son of God meant suffering and death (8:31; 9:31; 10:32–34, 45), being his follower involves serving others, not ruling over them (9:35; John 10:11).

Mark 10:45

Jesus offered his own example to demonstrate what leadership in God’s Kingdom means. • Jesus understands his death as a ransom. A ransom was a payment made to free a slave or captive. • The expression for many is probably an allusion to Isa 53:12, where *many* means *all* (cp. Rom 5:15, 18–20). Jesus died as the substitute for all. Later, Jesus would speak of his blood as being poured out for many (Mark 14:24).

Mark 10:46

they reached Jericho: The journey Jesus began in 10:1 was nearing its conclusion. Jericho was the last major city in the Jordan River Valley before Jerusalem. It may be the oldest continually occupied city in the world. In Jesus’ day, it was no longer located on the much smaller site of Old Testament times (Tell es-Sultan) but had been moved and greatly enlarged. The road from Jericho up to Jerusalem was steep, with a difference in elevation of about 3,000 feet (about 1,000 meters). • The large crowd following Jesus might have been fellow pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for Passover, but they certainly show Jesus’ great popularity and charisma. • A blind beggar . . . was sitting beside the road: This was a good location for collecting alms from religious pilgrims going to Jerusalem.

Mark 10:46–52

The healing of blind Bartimaeus is the last healing miracle recorded in Mark. This event and the healing of the blind man in 8:22–26 form bookends around this section (see Mark Book Introduction, “Literary Features”). It is also a bridge to Jesus’ entrance into Jerusalem as Israel’s Messiah in 11:1–11. Bartimaeus’s confession (Jesus, Son of David) prepares the reader for the confession of the people upon Jesus’ arrival in Jerusalem (11:10).

Mark 10:47–48

Bartimaeus heard: Jesus’ great fame had spread to Jericho, even as it had spread to Gentile areas (3:8). • Jesus, Son of David: Mark does not explain how Bartimaeus knew of Jesus’ Davidic ancestry. Perhaps he knew that Jesus was the Messiah. The blind man, however, did not here associate this title with political or military goals as did the vast majority of people in his day. Instead, Bartimaeus focused on the fact that Jesus was concerned with bringing God’s Kingdom to the poor, maimed, lame, and blind, and he requested mercy and healing (10:51)—which was in harmony with Jesus’ own understanding (cp. Luke 4:18–19).

Mark 10:50

threw aside his coat: Bartimaeus’s response is best understood as simply a spontaneous act of joy and anticipation

rather than as a symbolic casting off of his old way of life or leaving all to follow Jesus.

Mark 10:51

Bartimaeus's request, I want to see! revealed his faith, without which he might simply have asked for alms. The reports he had heard about Jesus enabled him to cry out for the miracle of sight.

Mark 10:52

The man's faith was rewarded, and he was healed (literally *saved*; see 5:23, 28, 34; 6:56; Matt 9:22; Luke 8:48). The healing was performed without touch, in contrast to the healing of the blind man in Mark 8:22–26. Bartimaeus followed Jesus (see also 1:18; 2:14–15; 6:1; 8:34; 10:21, 28, 32) down the road (cp. 1:2–3; 10:32).

Mark 11:1

Jerusalem was Jesus' goal. During the week before his crucifixion, Jesus apparently stayed in Bethany with his disciples (11:11–12; 14:3–9). • The Mount of Olives is frequently associated with the site of the final judgment (Zech 14:4) and the place where the Messiah will manifest himself (Ezek 11:23; 43:1–5; see also Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.8.6). • As he did at other times, Jesus sent two of them (see Mark 6:7).

Mark 11:1–13:37

This section centers on Jesus' relationship to the Jerusalem Temple. Mark's geographical arrangement places in 11:1–16:8 all his accounts of Jesus' teachings and events associated with Jerusalem. • The section concludes (13:1–37) with Jesus' second extended teaching discourse (see 4:1–34), now focusing on the destruction of the Temple and the coming of the Son of Man. It is the climax for numerous statements within 11:1–13:37 concerning the divine judgment about to fall on Jerusalem and the Temple (see especially 11:12–25 and 12:1–12).

Mark 11:2–3

There have already been numerous examples of Jesus' supernatural knowledge (2:8; 3:5; 5:30, 32; 8:17, 31), but the people's acceptance of the reply that the Lord needs it (11:3, 6) suggests that Jesus had prearranged it (cp. 14:13–16). Jesus had intentionally planned to enter Jerusalem in fulfillment of Zech 9:9.

Mark 11:3

The Lord needs it and will return it soon: Mark's readers have already seen the word *Lord* used to refer to Jesus (1:3; 2:28; 5:19; see also 12:36–37; 13:35), so they would under-

stand it as referring to the Lord Jesus Christ, who needed the colt (see also Rom 10:9; Phil 2:11).

Mark 11:4–6

The disciples obeyed the instructions of Jesus. They found everything just as he had said.

Mark 11:7–8

the colt . . . he sat on it: Cp. Zech 9:9; some of the people undoubtedly understood that they were witnessing the arrival of the Messiah. • The disciples made a seat for Jesus with their outer garments and others spread garments and branches from nearby trees into an honorary pathway for Jesus to ride upon to Jerusalem (see 1 Kgs 1:38–48; 2 Kgs 9:13).

Mark 11:9–10

Praise God! (Greek *Hosanna*): By the first century AD, *Hosanna* was no longer used literally as a cry for rescue from enemies but had become an idiomatic expression of joy and jubilation (cp. "Praise the Lord!" as used today). For the people, it was the exuberant welcome (Luke 19:38–40) of a famous pilgrim, the prophet from Galilee (Matt 21:11). The miracle of raising Lazarus from the dead might have contributed to the excitement of the day (John 12:9–11), but even the disciples did not truly understand this event until later (John 12:16). For Jesus, though, it was a fulfillment of prophecy. Jesus prepared for the occasion carefully and offered himself to the people of Israel as God's Anointed, the Messiah.

Mark 11:11

The account ends surprisingly: The exuberant crowd disappears and Jesus' actual entrance into the Temple is anticlimactic in comparison to his approach. Apparently, in the minds of the people, nothing important had taken place. Jesus' looking around prepares the reader for God's judgment on the Temple (11:15–17).

Mark 11:12–25

In the synoptic Gospels, Jesus' messianic entry into Jerusalem is intimately associated with the cleansing of the Temple (see 11:15–17; cp. Matt 21:1–17; Luke 19:28–48). In John, however, the account of the cleansing is recorded early in Jesus' ministry (John 2:13–22). It is uncertain whether there were two separate cleansings of the Temple (an early event recorded in John and this later event recorded in Matthew, Mark, and Luke) or just one cleansing recorded at different places by John and the synoptic writers. • In Mark's account, the cursing of the fig tree (Mark 11:12–14, 20–25) forms an *inclusio* (bookends) around the cleansing of the Temple (11:15–19). Mark thus indicates that Jesus' cleansing

of the Temple should be interpreted in light of his cursing of the fig tree—as an act of judgment rather than reformation.

Mark 11:13–14

it was too early in the season for fruit: Jesus did not curse the fig tree merely because it lacked fruit. Rather, he was performing a prophetic sign act like those of earlier prophets ([Isa 20](#); [Jer 13:1–11](#); [19:1–13](#); [Ezek 4](#)). Just as Jesus judged the fruitless fig tree, so too he judged the Temple and the worship of Israel, in which he found no fruit. This judgment was fulfilled in AD 70 with the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple by the Romans.

Mark 11:15–16

When they returned to the temple, Jesus was very upset about the buying and selling of sacrificial animals and the money exchange. It was supervised by priests, who alone could certify that a potential sacrificial offering was acceptable. Selling animals for sacrifices guaranteed that they only used animals that had no imperfections in temple services.

They placed exchange tables throughout Jerusalem and inside the temple. They did this on the fifteenth of Adar, the month before Passover. The exchange rate usually had a 4- to 8-percent fee. Because of the large number of half-shekels (see [Exodus 30:11–16](#)) and sacrifices involved, the money exchange and the sale of sacrificial animals was quite profitable.

Jewish writings of the time criticized priests for gaining wealth by taking advantage of poor people. Jesus did not oppose the temple or the system of sacrifices ([Mark 1:44](#); [Matthew 5:17–19](#), [23](#); [17:24–27](#); [Luke 17:14](#); [Acts 6:7](#); [21:20–26](#)). But he saw this profit-making as theft. It did not honor the temple as a holy place.

The actions of Jesus likely affected fewer people than many think. These actions occurred in one area of the large Court of the Gentiles. Most people in other parts of the temple did not see it happen.

The lack of interference by the Roman authorities suggests that they did not observe the event or did not regard it as a riot or a political rebellion. At the trial of Jesus, they did not mention this action. It was not a big attempt to stop all activities like this, but it was a symbolic act pointing to the judgment that was coming upon the temple and the city.

Mark 11:15–19

The largest area of the temple in Jerusalem was the Court of the Gentiles. Covered porches surrounded it. This was probably where the selling took place.

Mark 11:16

to carry merchandise through the temple courts: People also misused the temple by using it as a quick way to get from one part of the city to another. Other rabbis also forbade this practice (see *Mishnah Berakhot* 9.5; see Josephus, *Against Apion* 2.8).

Mark 11:17

Jesus quoted [Isa 56:7](#) and [Jer 7:11](#) in defense of his action. The first quotation emphasizes the importance of the Temple for Gentiles. God's house was intended by its very architecture (i.e., the Court of the Gentiles) to assist Gentiles in becoming children of Abraham. Jesus' act of judgment fell upon the leaders of Israel for hindering the Gentiles' access to the Temple. They were desecrating the Temple by taking part of the Temple specifically designated as a house of prayer for all nations and turning it into a den of thieves through the profiteering taking place.

Mark 11:18

The leading priests and teachers of religious law plotted to kill Jesus because they feared him. His great influence among the people, the amazement created by his actions, and the influence of his teaching threatened their position (see [3:6](#); [12:12](#); [14:1–2](#), [10–11](#)). Their response shows that reform was not enough: God's judgment was necessary.

Mark 11:19

Jesus and His disciples went out: They likely went back to Bethany ([11:11](#); [14:3](#)).

Mark 11:20–21

Jesus' miraculous power to judge the fig tree testified to his authority to bring about the judgment of Jerusalem that he had foretold. If Mark's original audience was hearing his Gospel read to them in the late AD 60s, they knew that Roman legions were already enacting this prophetic judgment against Jerusalem.

Mark 11:22–23

The importance of Jesus' words is emphasized by his emphatic I tell you the truth. • This mountain probably indicates the Temple Mount, not the Mount of Olives. The judgment of the Temple is the focus of [11:12–25](#); it will be referred to again in [12:9](#) and at great length in [13:1–37](#). Jesus' reference to destroying the Temple would later be raised at his trial ([14:58](#)) and crucifixion ([15:29](#)).

Mark 11:24–25

Two additional sayings on prayer are tied to [11:23](#) by the word believe. In the first ([11:24](#)), we are told that we will

receive what we ask for (see [Matt 7:7](#)) if we pray with the faith described in [Mark 11:23](#). • Forgiveness is the second condition for answered prayer. Only when we forgive others can our most important prayer, that God forgive us, be answered ([Matt 5:23–24](#); [6:12](#), [14–15](#); [Luke 6:37](#); [11:4](#); cp. [Luke 7:41–43](#), [47](#); [Eph 4:32](#); [Col 3:13](#)).

Mark 11:27

Upon returning again to Jerusalem (see [11:1](#), [11](#), [15](#)), Jesus and the disciples entered the Temple. The frequent repetition of Jerusalem reminds readers of what would soon take place there ([10:32–34](#); see [8:31](#); [9:31](#); [14:1–16:8](#)). • In the Temple, Jesus encountered the leading priests, the teachers of religious law, and the elders. These three groups made up the seventy-one-member high council (the ruling body of the nation). From earlier encounters with them ([8:31](#); see also [14:43](#), [53](#); [15:1](#)), we expect them to oppose Jesus.

Mark 11:27–33

Jesus cleansed the temple ([11:15–17](#); [Matthew 21:12–22](#); [Luke 19:45–46](#)). Then his opponents questioned his authority to do so (see also [Matt 21:23–27](#); [Luke 20:1–8](#); compare [John 2:18–22](#)).

Mark 11:28

Jesus has authority to:

- drive out demons ([1:22](#), [27](#); [5:1–13](#)),
- heal ([1:29–2:12](#); [5:21–43](#)),
- forgive sins ([2:10](#)), and
- cleanse the temple.

His authority came from God, but the religious leaders refused to accept it.

Mark 11:29–30

Jesus often responded to his opponents' questions with other questions (for example, [2:8–9](#), [19](#), [25–26](#); [3:4](#), [23](#); [10:3](#), [38](#); see also [12:16](#)). This is an effective way both to teach and to refute.

Mark 11:31–32

Jesus clearly placed his opponents in a bind, for either a “yes” or a “no” would damage their reputation and authority in the eyes of the people. Denying John’s prophetic authority would probably anger the people. Affirming it would mean that they should have accepted what John said, including what he said about Jesus. This answer would also answer their own question ([11:28](#)).

Mark 11:33

In answering, “We don’t know,” the religious leaders of the nation admitted that they could not answer a simple ques-

tion that the people had no difficulty in answering: John was sent from God. They thus forfeited the religious leadership of the nation on this question. Their hardness of heart ([3:5](#); [7:6](#)), their unwillingness to see ([4:12](#)), and their deliberate refusal to accept the truth made further discussion fruitless. Their blindness and hostility toward God’s servants John the Baptist and Jesus, their desecration of the Temple, and their plot to kill Jesus all revealed why God’s judgment would come within that very generation ([13:30](#)).

Mark 12:1

The antecedent to them is the religious leaders of [11:27](#) (also in [12:12](#)). • The beginning description of the story comes from [Isa 5:1–7](#). Jesus’ audience knew the book of Isaiah well and would have immediately recalled this allegory of the vineyard.

Mark 12:1–12

The events of [11:27–12:44](#) all take place in the Temple (see [11:27](#); [13:1](#)). This story (literally *parable*) is intimately tied to the previous question about Jesus’ authority ([11:27–33](#)) by the introductory words, Then Jesus began teaching them. This parable is an extended reply by Jesus to the religious leaders. • Jesus intended his audience to interpret this parable in light of [Isa 5:1–7](#), a similar story of someone planting a vineyard, building a lookout tower, putting a fence around the vineyard, and digging a pit for a wine vat. A similar question is asked: What do you suppose the owner of the vineyard will do? ([Mark 12:9](#); cp. [Isa 5:4](#)). Isaiah specifically identifies the vineyard as the people of Israel ([Isa 5:7](#)); Jesus’ hearers and Mark’s readers would similarly have understood the present story as an allegory about the Israelites. Other details in the story are also clearly meant to be interpreted allegorically: The tenants represent the leaders of Israel; the owner represents God; the servants represent the Old Testament prophets; the beloved son represents Jesus, the Son of God; the murder of the son represents Jesus’ crucifixion; and the giving of the vineyard to others represents the judgment coming upon Israel ([Mark 11:15–17](#); [13:1–37](#)). The interpretation would have been more clear to Mark’s readers than to Jesus’ original audience, but the religious leaders who were Jesus’ contemporaries understood it clearly enough that they sought to kill him ([12:12](#)).

Mark 12:2–5

The time of the grape harvest probably refers to the time, some four years after planting, when a new vineyard would produce its first harvest. The owner’s share of the crop would have been a quantity of grapes or wine, given in payment for the lease of the vineyard. • In the Old Testament, prophets are often referred to as servants ([Jer 7:25–26](#); [Amos 3:7](#); [Zech 1:6](#)); they were repeatedly mis-

treated and killed by Israelite leaders (1 Kgs 18:13; 19:10, 14; 2 Chr 24:20–27; 36:15–16; Jer 26:20–23; Neh 9:26; see Matt 23:34, 37; 1 Thes 2:15).

Mark 12:6

Mark's early audience would have quickly connected *beloved son* with Jesus (compare 1:11; 9:7; see also 1:1; 3:11; 5:7).

Mark 12:7

The reasoning of the tenants is unclear to us, although it was apparently clear to the original hearers, requiring no further explanation (cp. Matt 21:38; Luke 20:14). Perhaps with the son's coming, they assumed that the father had died and that the murder of the son would leave the vineyard without a living claimant. Then ownership would fall to those who had been working the vineyard for years.

Mark 12:8

threw him out of the vineyard: This action shows even more dishonor, because they did not bury him. Compare with Hebrews 13:12–13.

Mark 12:9

The parable concludes with two rhetorical questions (cp. 3:23, 33; 4:13; 7:18; 8:12). The first corresponds to what the "Lord of Heaven's Armies" says in the parable of the vineyard (Isa 5:5–7). Although some interpret Jesus' answer as meaning that God would replace the evil Jewish leaders (Mark 11:27; 12:12) with more faithful ones, Mark's readers likely would have understood the others to whom the vineyard would be given as the Gentile church (cp. Matt 21:43; Rom 9:25–33; 11:13–24). Thus, Jesus' parable connects with the coming destruction of Jerusalem (Mark 11:15–19; 13:1–37; 14:58; 15:29).

Mark 12:10–11

In his second rhetorical question, Jesus used a quotation from Ps 118:22–23. The rejected stone (the Son) had become the cornerstone of God's Kingdom (cp. Acts 4:11; 1 Pet 2:4, 6–7). The phrase is traditionally understood as the buried cornerstone that is part of the foundation, but it could be the capstone at the top of a building that marks its completion. Whichever stone is meant, it was the most important one. Despite the evil intention of the builders—the religious leaders—all they did was in accordance with God's will (Acts 4:28), which was wonderful to see. Those who put Jesus to death were God's instruments in his plan for the Son of Man to give his life as a ransom for many (Mark 10:45).

Mark 12:12

the leaders: For the second time, the crowd stopped their evil plans (see 11:31–32; 14:1–2).

Mark 12:13–17

After they failed to question the authority of Jesus, his enemies tried to turn the people against him. From the beginning, it is clear that the Pharisees and the supporters of Herod (see 3:6) were not sincere. They were trying to trap Jesus so he would say something that could lead to his arrest.

The question *Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar or not?* was carefully planned. It put Jesus in a difficult situation where any answer seems wrong. If he said yes, the people might turn against him, because they hated Roman rule and taxes. If he said no, he could

Mark 12:14

taxes: The Greek word refers to a poll tax, a tax each person paid to the government (compare Luke 2:1–2 and Acts 5:37).

Mark 12:15

- Jesus gave a surprising response that showed his wisdom.
- *a denarius*: The tax likely had to be paid using Roman coins.

Mark 12:16

The picture and title on the coin were almost certainly of Tiberius Caesar, who ruled from AD 14 to 37. The inscription (words written on the coin) said, "Tiberius Caesar Augustus, Son of [the] Divine Augustus" on one side and "High Priest" on the other.

Mark 12:17

give to Caesar what belongs to Caesar: Jesus' words cannot be taken as those of an anti-Roman zealot opposing Jewish taxation by Caesar. Jesus clearly indicates elsewhere that he was opposed to the zealot cause (see Matt 5:9, 39, 41; 26:52). However, Jesus' statement cannot be understood as pro-Roman, either, because service to God is fundamental, and God is ultimately over Caesar. Like the evil farmers in the previous parable, the religious leaders had not given God what belonged to him.

Mark 12:18

This is the only place in Mark where the Sadducees are mentioned by name, although they are included in references to the leading priests (see 8:31; 10:33; 11:18, 27). Sadducees did not believe in the resurrection from the dead (see Acts 4:1–2; 23:8).

Mark 12:18–27

This is the third controversy story of the series begun in 11:27. As in most New Testament references to the Sadducees, the setting is the Temple (Matt 22:23–33 // Luke 20:27–40; Acts 4:1–3; 5:12, 17; 22:30–23:10; the exceptions are Matt 3:7; 16:1–12). • The Sadducees’ question (Mark 12:19–23) was carefully crafted and based on a commandment of Moses (Deut 25:5–6; see Gen 38:6–11; Ruth 4:1–22). Since all seven men could not have the woman as wife in the resurrection, and since none of them had a special claim, the Sadducees thought that they had proven the absurdity of the doctrine of the resurrection and refuted the Pharisees and Jesus (cp. Matt 12:41–42; Luke 16:19–31; see also Mark 8:31; 9:31; 10:34).

Mark 12:19

The Sadducees based their views only on the books of Moses. • Like the Pharisees (12:14), they addressed Jesus as Teacher. The Sadducees were fond of debating with religious teachers (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.1.4).

Mark 12:24–27

Jesus’ response had two elements. First, he rebuked the Sadducees’ ignorance of the Scriptures (i.e., the Old Testament), where the resurrection of the dead is referred to most clearly in the Prophets (Isa 26:19; Ezek 37:1–14) and the Writings (Job 19:26; Pss 16:9–11; 49:15; 73:23–26; Dan 12:2). However, the Sadducees accepted only the Torah (Genesis–Deuteronomy), so Jesus answered them from the Torah. The reference to God as the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob (see Exod 3:6, 15–16) showed that God’s covenant with the patriarchs could not be broken by death. They were still alive (Matt 8:11–12; 13:17; Luke 16:19–31; John 8:56), for God is the God of the living, not the dead. God’s covenant relationship with his people extends beyond their physical death, which means that the afterlife must be a reality. • Second, Jesus challenged the Sadducees’ ignorance of God’s power. They thought that life in the resurrection would have to be an extension of mortal life. Instead, it is life raised to an entirely new level. In this new existence, there is no need for sexual reproduction because there is no more death. The intimacy of marriage is superseded by fellowship with a multitude of fellow believers and with God (Mark 10:29–30; Matt 19:28–29; Luke 18:29–30; Rev 21:1–4). It is in this respect that resurrected believers will be like the angels in heaven. • Jesus’ argument demonstrates his wisdom before his opponents and affirms the hope of the resurrection for his followers. Jesus is “the resurrection and the life” (John 11:25); he has conquered death and assured those who believe in him that they will “not perish but have eternal life” (John 3:16).

Mark 12:28

Of all the commandments: The Torah (Genesis–Deuteronomy) contains 613 separate commandments, and Jewish teachers frequently debated about which were more important than others. No command was considered unimportant, but some were recognized as more fundamental than others (see Matt 22:40). Rabbi Hillel’s answer to this question was, “What is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor” (*Babylonian Shabbat* 31a; see also *Tobit* 4:15). Other suggestions included Prov 3:6; Isa 33:15–16; 56:1; Amos 5:4; Mic 6:8; and Hab 2:4.

Mark 12:28–34

After the three hostile challenges of 11:27–12:27, the reader might expect the next question to Jesus to be hostile (see 11:28; 12:13, 15, 19–23), but this was not a hostile counter. Earlier references in Mark to the teachers of religious law have portrayed them as antagonistic (2:6–7, 16; 3:22; 7:1, 5; 8:31; 9:14; 10:33; 11:18, 27), and Jesus will warn the crowds against their hypocrisy (12:38–40), but this teacher was positively inclined toward Jesus (12:28, 32) and praised him (12:32–33). Jesus described the man’s answer to his question as having understanding, and Jesus said that the man was not far from the Kingdom of God (12:34).

Mark 12:29–31

Jesus’ reply combined two widely separated commands from the Torah. • The first, Deut 6:4–5, was probably the best known passage in the Old Testament, for it was repeated twice daily by observant Jews. It is called the *Shema* because it begins with the word Listen (Hebrew *shema*). The first command corresponds to the first part of the Ten Commandments (Exod 20:2–11), which deals with a person’s relationship to God. • The oneness of God is foundational to Jewish and Christian monotheism and is the basis for the command to love God with all one’s heart (thinking and affection), soul (desire and feeling), mind (understanding), and strength (energy and power). • The second command is from Lev 19:18. It corresponds to the second part of the Ten Commandments (Exod 20:12–17), which concerns a person’s relationship with other people. The second command is based on the natural inclination of people to look after themselves. Its importance to the early church can be seen in its frequent repetition (Matt 5:43–44; 19:19; 25:31–46; Rom 13:8–10; Gal 5:14; Jas 2:8; *Didache* 1.2; 2.7). The two commands are not independent, but are intimately associated as one commandment. Their integration precludes religious mysticism that addresses only a person’s relationship with God or humanism that addresses only human relationships.

Mark 12:32–33

The scribe's affirmation adds emphasis to the importance of these two commands for authentic devotion.

Mark 12:34

The account ends with Jesus' commending the teacher of religious law for recognizing that this twofold command was more important than burnt offerings and sacrifices (see [Hos 6:6](#)). We are left uncertain as to the fate of this man. He was not far from the Kingdom of God, but did he enter it? Mark might have intentionally left this question unanswered so that each reader would wrestle with the question, *Have I entered the Kingdom of God?*

Mark 12:35–37

After having answered various questions, mostly from opponents, Jesus now asked a question (see [8:27](#); [Matt 17:25](#); [21:31](#); [Luke 10:36](#)). The Messiah was considered the son of David because of such passages as [Isa 9:2–7](#); [11:1–5](#); [Jer 23:5–6](#); [33:15–16](#); [Ezek 34:23–24](#); [37:24–28](#). With his question, Jesus did not deny that the Messiah was a descendant of David ([Mark 10:47–48](#); [11:10](#); see [Rom 1:3–4](#)), but he demonstrated that this description, while correct, is inadequate. The Messiah is far more!

Mark 12:36

[Psalm 110:1](#) is the Old Testament verse most quoted in the New Testament. Since David authored the psalm, the statement "The Lord [God] said to my [David's] Lord [the Messiah]" indicates that the Messiah is David's Lord. Thus, the Messiah could not simply be David's son. He is the Son of God who sits at God's right hand ([Mark 14:62](#)) and will come to judge the world ([8:38](#); [13:24–27](#), [32–37](#)).

Mark 12:38–39

teachers of religious law: See [1:22](#). The warning here is similar to the one against the Pharisees and Herod in [8:15](#). The scribes broke the two greatest commands ([12:30–31](#)). They broke the first command by failing to love God and failing to reserve for him alone the reverence and adoration they sought for themselves. • Flowing robes were probably the garments worn by religious men; respectful greetings perhaps meant being called "Rabbi" (see [Matt 23:7](#)). The seats of honor were in the front of the synagogue facing the congregation.

Mark 12:40

The teachers of religious law broke the second command by failing to love their neighbors, as was seen in their cheating widows of their property. They clearly were cheating the most vulnerable and needy people despite God's concern for

widows ([Deut 14:29](#); [Pss 68:5](#); [146:9](#); [Isa 1:17](#); [Jer 7:6](#); [49:11](#)) and his condemnation of those who mistreat them ([Isa 1:23](#); [Ezek 22:7](#); [Zech 7:10](#); [Mal 3:5](#)). The scribes wore a hypocritical cloak of false piety (see [Matt 6:5–6](#); [Luke 18:11–12](#)). • they will be more severely punished: In the final judgment ([Mark 9:42–48](#); see [Luke 14:11](#)).

Mark 12:41–42

The word translated collection box can refer to a building within the Temple compound in which Temple money was stored, but here it refers to one of thirteen money chests into which gifts were placed. As Jesus watched, many rich people put in large sums. Then he noticed a poor widow put in two small coins. (The use of the Roman term *quadrans* supports the view that Mark wrote his Gospel for the church in Rome; see Mark Book Introduction, "Audience.") These two coins were worth one sixty-fourth of a *denarius*, a normal day's pay ([Matt 20:1–2](#)).

Mark 12:41–44

This account of a poor widow highlights the contrast between the falsely pious religious leaders ([12:38–40](#)) and those who truly love God. The emphasis of the passage falls on Jesus' pronouncement, I tell you the truth, in which the widow is described as having given more than the rich.

Mark 12:43–44

Jesus called his disciples to hear his teaching (see [3:23](#); [6:7](#); [8:1](#); [10:42](#); see also [7:14](#); [8:34](#)). Jesus' pronouncement in [12:43](#) revealed a radical difference between his thinking and that of the world. No one would have named a building after the widow for her gift of two small coins, but Jesus and his Father look at a person's heart ([1 Sam 16:7](#)). The widow was doing exactly what Jesus told the rich young ruler to do ([Mark 10:21](#)) and what he taught his disciples ([1:18](#), [20](#); [8:34–37](#); [10:28–29](#)). Like the woman of [14:3–9](#), the poor widow loved God with all her heart, soul, mind, and strength ([12:30](#)).

Mark 13:1

Leaving the Temple, Jesus was heading to the Mount of Olives ([13:3](#)). • look at these magnificent buildings! The sight of the Temple would have been awe-inspiring. It was the largest temple complex in the world, with immense stones. One stone that has been uncovered in the western wall is estimated to weigh 600 tons. With its white stones, gold trim, and the gold-covered roof, the Temple complex looked like a snow-covered mountain; in the sun it was a blinding sight (Josephus, *War* 5.5.6). The Talmud says that "He who has not seen the temple in its full construction has never seen a glorious building in his life" (*Babylonian Sukkah* 51b).

Mark 13:1–37

This passage brings to a conclusion the section begun at 11:1. Israel's failure to produce fruit (11:12–26; 12:38–40) and its leaders' hostility toward God's anointed, the Messiah (11:1–11, 27–33; 12:13–17, 18–27), would result in judgment and the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple.

Mark 13:2

Jesus' reply to the disciples was shocking. This glorious and massive Temple complex, a symbol of strength and permanence and God's favor for the Jews, would be totally, irrevocably destroyed. • Not one stone will be left on top of another! Jesus' prediction emphasized the total devastation that would result from the Roman army's systematic attack on the entire Temple complex (Josephus, *Antiquities* 6.9.1; 7.1.1.). To say that Jesus' prediction was not fulfilled because some of the foundation stones still stand is to misunderstand the language of prophecy. One does not expect a prophet to say that 97.9% of these stones will be removed! Anyone in the first century who visited Jerusalem after AD 70 would have acknowledged that Jesus' prediction had been fulfilled.

Mark 13:3–4

Andrew appeared here with the trio, Peter, James, and John (5:37; 9:2; 14:33), completing the two sets of brothers (1:16–20; 3:16–18). • Jesus' prediction elicited two questions from the disciples. Although some scholars argue that the second question goes beyond the first in looking to the coming of the Son of Man at the end of the age, it is best to interpret these two questions as focusing on the time and the sign associated with the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple (cp. 13:29–30; Luke 21:7). These questions follow naturally from Jesus' prediction in Mark 13:2. The desire to know the sign reflected the disciples' desire to be forewarned and prepared for all . . . these things.

Mark 13:5–6

Jesus warned his followers not to be misled by the many false messiahs who would come claiming, 'I am the Messiah' and would deceive many into following them. These false claimants would profess to be the long-awaited Jewish Messiah (not Jesus per se) or to speak on the Messiah's behalf. Such claimants included Theudas the Galilean (Acts 5:36), Simon the son of Gioras, and John of Gischala, who deceived many in the AD 60s.

Mark 13:5–23

This section is often divided into two parts, 13:5–13 and 13:14–23. The first part is often interpreted as describing the destruction of Jerusalem, which occurred in AD 70, while the second part is taken to describe the coming of the Son of Man in the future. It is best, however, to interpret all of

13:5–23 as describing events surrounding the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 because: (1) 13:5–23 is Jesus' answer to the two questions (13:4) that deal with the destruction of Jerusalem (13:2); (2) The commands to flee Judea (13:14–16), the woe announced upon pregnant and nursing women (13:17), and the prayer that it not take place in winter (13:18) make sense if they refer to the events of AD 70 but not if they refer to the future return of Christ; (3) Three warnings in this passage (13:5, 9, 23) tie this passage together and indicate that 13:5–23 should be understood as a unit. • The subdivisions of this section are arranged as a chiasm (X-pattern): A: Deceivers claim to be the Messiah (13:5–6). B: There are reports of fighting and natural disasters (13:7–8). C: There is persecution of believers (13:9–13). B': The fighting in Judea and resulting tribulation begin (13:14–20). A': Deceivers claim to be the Messiah (13:21–23).

Mark 13:7

The Greek word translated must is also used in 8:31. In both instances, God's sovereignty over events is emphasized. • but the end won't follow immediately: These things would occur, and just as birth pains are followed by childbirth, God's judgment on Jerusalem would follow. However, these events did not indicate that it was going to happen right away.

Mark 13:9

The second watch out! warns of persecution that was to come upon Christians (see 6:11; 8:34–38; 10:30; see 4:17). Jewish Christians would be brought before local councils of Jewish leaders, who had authority over Jewish communities. We read of such a council in Matt 10:17 and probably in Matt 5:22 (see also Acts 4:1–22). • beaten in the synagogues: Paul's beatings in 2 Cor 11:24–25 were probably inflicted in the local synagogue. • The followers of Jesus would also be susceptible to trial before governors and kings (see Acts 23:24; 24:10–27; 25:1–26:32). Such trials were due to their being followers of Jesus (Mark 13:9, 13), not on account of real wrongdoing (see 1 Pet 4:14–16).

Mark 13:10

Such trials (13:9, 11) would be a means through which the Good News would be preached to all nations. This would all take place first—i.e., before the destruction of Jerusalem. For Paul's understanding of how the Good News had already been preached to every nation in his day, see Rom 16:26; Col 1:6, 23 (see also Rom 1:5, 8; 10:18; 15:19, 23).

Mark 13:11

A word of encouragement follows the warning of 13:9. Jesus' followers need not fear what they should say in these circumstances. The early followers of Jesus were generally un-

educated and without political influence (see [Acts 4:10–17](#); [1 Cor 1:26](#)), so this assurance would have comforted them. Believers are not prohibited from thinking about what they will say, but they need not worry about it.

Mark 13:12–13

There would be no single group, not even their own families, to whom persecuted Christians could automatically flee or turn for help (see [Matt 10:35–36](#); [Luke 12:53](#)). They would be universally hated because of their allegiance to Jesus (because you are my followers). Those who remain faithful to death (to the end) will be saved from eternal punishment (see also [Mark 8:35](#); [Rev 2:7](#), [10](#), [17](#), [26–28](#); [3:5](#), [12](#), [21](#)).

Mark 13:14

- *When you see the abomination of desolation*: Mark did not explain what this object would be, but Jewish audiences in the first century were familiar with the term. The prophet Daniel had foretold that such an object would stand in the temple in Jerusalem ([Daniel 9:27](#); [11:31](#)). Many Jews understood the events in Jerusalem from 167 to 164 BC, during the time of Antiochus IV Epiphanes, to be a fulfillment of that prophecy.

The deuterocanonical book of 1 Maccabees (a book accepted as Scripture by some Christian traditions), was written around 100 BC. It tells about the rule of Antiochus. It says that Antiochus and his followers set up “sacriligious object causing desecration on top of the altar for burnt offerings,” [1 Maccabees 1:54](#), 59).

- *standing where it should not be*: Given the historical context and references to Jerusalem and Judea, this phrase clearly refers to something inappropriate happening in the temple in Jerusalem ([Mark 13:2](#), [4,14](#)).
- *(let the reader understand)*: Mark urged his readers to focus on this sign, indicating it required careful thought and understanding. Mark wanted his audience to watch for a sign similar to what happened during the time of Antiochus Epiphanes.
- Although the phrase *the abomination of desolation* is grammatically neuter, the word *standing* is grammatically masculine. This may suggest a person behind the act, but it is not certain. The phrase can still refer to a thing or event.

Scholars suggest several possible meanings for the *abomination of desolation*. These include:

1. The emperor Caligula. In AD 39–40, he tried to place a statue of himself in the temple (Josephus, *Antiquities* 12.8.2–3).
2. Pontius Pilate, governor of Judea from AD 26–36. He brought Roman soldiers into Judea carrying military flags that Jews saw as idolatrous (Josephus, *War* 2.9.2–3).
3. The Zealots, a Jewish revolutionary group. Around AD 69–70, they committed violent acts in the temple, chose

an unqualified high priest, “entered the sanctuary with polluted feet” (Josephus, *War* 4.3.4–8).

4. The Roman general Titus. After he conquered Jerusalem in AD 70, he forced entry into the temple (Josephus, *War* 6.4.7).
5. Titus’ soldiers. They set up their military flags in the temple, offered sacrifices to them, and declared Titus emperor (Josephus, *War* 6.6.1).
6. The destruction of the temple itself in AD 70.
7. A future event. Some connect this to the coming of the antichrist (a future opponent of God; see [2 Thessalonians 2:3–4](#)).

The context and source of this expression help us rule out some of these views. In Daniel and 1 Maccabees, the phrase refers to the Temple, its altar, and its sacrifices. In [Mark 13:14–20](#), it is a sign that tells people to flee Judea. This sign must happen while there is still time to escape (before the Roman army surrounds Jerusalem).

Explanations 1 and 2 are too early. They would not have been a clear sign to flee Judea. They also did not actually defile the temple, and Christians did not leave Jerusalem at that time.

Explanations 4–6 are too late. They happened after Titus entered Jerusalem. By then, there was no time left to escape.

Explanation 7 refers to a future event. It does not match the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, which is the focus of [13:14–20](#). Also, the coming of the antichrist would not be limited to Judea.

Explanation 3 fits best. It took place in AD 69–70, shortly before Titus surrounded Jerusalem. This timing would have allowed a short time for Christians to leave the city. It also involved actions that defiled the holy place in the temple.

This view also helps distinguish between the sign and what happens next. The sign is the *abomination of desolation*, and what happens next is the great suffering and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple.

- *then*: At the appearance of the *abomination*, those in Judea were to *flee to the mountains*. The early church historian Eusebius says that a prophetic message (a message from God) was given to the church in Jerusalem. This message caused them to leave the city before it was destroyed (Eusebius, *Church History* 3.5.3).

Mark 13:14–20

Jesus now gave the sign requested in [13:4](#) and instructed his followers how to respond when they saw it. In [13:5–13](#), they were told not to be alarmed. Here they are told that those in Judea must flee to the hills.

Mark 13:15–16

A person relaxing on the roof of their Judean home should not even pack after seeing this sign, but come down and flee. Likewise, a person out in the field should not return home to retrieve his cloak. Believers were to flee from the approaching Roman army as soon as they saw the sign of [13:14](#).

Their movement was usually cautious, methodical (careful and step-by-step), and relentless (steady and not stopping). But Jesus warned people not to wait and see how things would develop.

Mark 13:17

The suffering of the weakest (*pregnant and nursing mothers*) shows that the coming disaster would be severe. On that day, the joy of being a mother would be accompanied by terrible trouble (see [Luke 1:25, 57–59](#)).

Mark 13:18

In winter, the wadis (canyon-like riverbeds) are flooded, travel is more difficult, and survival is harder.

Mark 13:19

greater anguish in those days than at any time since God created the world: Such hyperbole is common in Semitic expression; it heightens the terror of that horrible time and should not be taken as an exact statistical analysis of how this suffering ranks alongside other disasters. • And it will never be so great again: The events of [13:14–23](#) would not bring history to an end; history would continue after the destruction of the Temple in AD 70.

Mark 13:20

God's shortening of his timetable for the days of calamity is referred to frequently in intertestamental Jewish literature (e.g., *2 Esdras* 2:13; *2 Baruch* 20:1). This statement emphasizes the horrors of this tribulation experienced by God's people, but also God's mercy in shortening this time. • not a single person will survive: The whole population of Judea might have been destroyed if the days of anguish had been longer. • chosen ones (literally *elect*): Followers of Jesus.

Mark 13:21–23

The larger section ([13:5–23](#)) concludes with another warning about messianic pretenders. Here the pretenders are associated with the events of AD 70, whereas in [13:5–6](#) they were associated with the normal course of events. Along with false messiahs, prophets would appear and perform miraculous signs and wonders ([13:22](#)), hoping to deceive not only the Jews of Judea and Jerusalem but even the Christians (God's chosen ones). Jesus warned his followers not to

believe such reports. When the Messiah comes from heaven ([13:26](#)), everyone will see and know it (see [Rev 1:7](#)). • Watch out! This warning unifies the section ([Mark 13:5–23](#)) and brings it to a close. Jesus' teaching in this section was to warn his followers in Judea and Jerusalem not to be misled by false messianic hopes and claims. Many Jews succumbed to such claims in the late AD 60s, and Josephus (*Antiquities* 17.10.8) describes the great harm done by these pretenders, who encouraged the Jewish people to resist the Romans. Nothing should distract Christians from fleeing Judea and Jerusalem when they see the sacrilegious object that causes desecration taking place. • For Mark's readers in Rome, Jesus' message had a different application. Mark wanted his readers to watch out for those who promised timetables for prophecy to be fulfilled. They could not know the time ([13:32](#)), and a frenzy about the second coming of Christ was forbidden, but they were to be alert ([13:33–37](#)) and prepare themselves for persecution ([13:9–13](#); see [8:34–38](#)) according to Jesus' words of encouragement ([13:11, 13](#)).

Mark 13:24–25

Some of the language used in the New Testament to describe Jesus' second coming, such as the "trumpet call of God" ([1 Thes 4:16](#)), appears to be metaphorical, and in the Old Testament, cosmic language is frequently used to describe historical events metaphorically (see [Isa 11:1–9; 13:9–11; Jer 4:23–28; Ezek 32:1–16](#)). So it is possible that this imagery could refer to a past event, such as the destruction of Jerusalem, if that is the meaning of [Mark 13:24–27](#). However, the New Testament writers clearly understood the coming of the Son of Man to be the visible and personal return of Jesus in the future (see [Acts 1:9–11](#)).

Mark 13:24–27

At that time, after the anguish of those days: Many scholars argue that the cosmic signs of [13:24–25](#), the coming of the Son of Man in [13:26](#), and the gathering of the chosen ones from throughout the world in [13:27](#) are metaphorical ways of referring to the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 and to the vindication of the Son of Man by that event. The traditional interpretation, though, is that, whereas the former material refers to the destruction of Jerusalem, this passage refers to the coming of the Son of Man (the *parousia*) that will occur at the end of history. This interpretation fits better for several reasons: (1) After the anguish of those days means after the destruction of Jerusalem, not during it, and at that time (literally *in those days*) could occur at any time after the events of [13:5–23](#); (2) several words used in [13:26](#) are used elsewhere to describe the coming of the Son of Man: glory ([8:38](#)), power and clouds ([14:62](#)); and (3) in light of the early church's longing and praying for the return of the Lord Jesus ([1 Cor 16:22; Rev 22:20](#)), Mark's readers would have interpreted [Mark 13:26](#) as the second coming of Jesus, which

will bring history as we know it to a close. The prophets, Jesus, and the Gospel writers described this event as though seen through a telescope, and the distance between events is unclear; no one knows the time for this event except God himself (13:32). The events of 13:5–23 and 13:24–27 are part of the same great, divine act that includes the coming of the Son of Man, his ministry, death, and resurrection, the judgment of Jerusalem in AD 70, and the Son of Man's final coming in glory.

Mark 13:27

The Son of Man, at his coming, will gather his chosen people—those who believe in him and follow him—from all over the world (see Zech 2:6) and from the farthest ends of the earth and heaven (see Deut 13:7; 30:4; Isa 42:10; 62:11). This hope is expressed frequently in the Old Testament (e.g., Ps 107:2–3; Isa 11:11–16; 27:12–13; 43:5–13; 49:12; 60:1–9; Jer 31:10). For Mark's readers, this passage would have provided encouragement to endure and remain faithful despite the persecutions foretold in Mark 13:9–13. The Son of Man's coming will also bring judgment on the unrighteous (8:38; 13:32–37; Matt 13:41–43; 24:36–51; 25:1–12, 31–46).

Mark 13:28–31

This passage contains the lesson (literally *parable*) of the fig tree (13:28–30) and two sayings (13:30–31). It is closely tied to 13:4–23 by the words all these things (13:4) and the expression when you see (13:29; cp. 13:14).

Mark 13:29

his return (literally *he/it is near*): The Greek has no explicit subject, so the choice between “he is near” or “it is near” depends on whether 13:29–30 refers to 13:4–23 or to 13:24–27. The NLT text understands it as referring to the return of the Son of Man. Because words in 13:4 are echoed in 13:29 and 30 (see study note on 13:28–31), others interpret it as referring to the destruction of Jerusalem. Just as the sprouting of the fig tree is a herald of summer, the desolating sacrilege (13:14) would be a harbinger of Jerusalem's destruction.

Mark 13:30

This generation was to witness the fulfillment of these events. That generation did witness the destruction of Jerusalem. Those, however, who hold that all these things refers to the coming of the Son of Man have to interpret this generation as meaning something other than “people alive at this time.” It could refer to the continued existence of the Jewish people, the whole human race, the Christian community, or the last generation of the end time.

Mark 13:31

Jesus personally guaranteed what he had said. My words include specifically what Jesus said in the whole discourse of Mark 13:1–37. Mark's readers would have understood this as guaranteeing the truth of all Jesus' teachings known to them (Luke 1:2). Like the Old Testament Scriptures (see Isa 40:8), Jesus' words are eternal. His teachings are more abiding than the fundamental elements of creation. The basic elements of creation will pass away (see also Ps 102:25–26; Isa 40:6–8; 51:6; Matt 5:18; Luke 16:17; 2 Pet 3:7, 10; Rev 20:11), but Jesus' words will never disappear.

Mark 13:32

The statement no one knows the day or hour (cp. Acts 1:7) introduces the warning to be watchful (Mark 13:33–37) and discourages speculation. • Jesus refers to himself as the Son, higher than the angels in an ascending hierarchy that begins with no one and ends with only the Father. The authenticity of this saying is assured by the limitation it places on the Son's knowledge, something the early church would not likely have imagined—in the apocryphal gospels (about AD 150–300), the tendency is to exalt and magnify Jesus' divine attributes (e.g., see the *Infancy Gospel of Thomas*). In the miracle of the incarnation, Jesus experienced limitation (Mark 10:40; 13:32). If the Son himself did not know the day or hour, Christians should refrain from seeking such knowledge for themselves.

Mark 13:32–37

Just as 13:28–31 seems to pick up the theme of 13:5–23 in speaking of the destruction of Jerusalem, 13:32–37 apparently picks up the theme of 13:24–27 and speaks of the coming of the Son of Man. An introductory warning against speculations concerning the end time (13:32) is followed by a warning to be on guard because one cannot know the time of the end (13:33). A story illustrates the need to be ready for the Lord's return (13:34), and its application repeats the need to watch lest they be found unprepared (13:35–36); the concluding warning is also for watchfulness (13:37).

Mark 13:33–37

These verses repeat a basic warning: *Be on your guard and stay alert! ... Keep watch!* The repetition shows that they needed to stay alert (be watchful and ready).

Mark 13:34–35

The point of the story is not that the return of the Lord is uncertain or unexpected (see Matt 24:45–51; 25:1–30; Luke 12:36–38; 19:12–27), but that there will be no sign or warning of his coming. The parable is allegorical in at least two respects, with the master (Greek *kurios*) understood as

the Lord [kurios] Jesus Christ and the slaves or household servants as the Christian community. But to allegorize the gatekeeper as the apostles or Peter was a post-New Testament development. • in the evening, at midnight, before dawn (literally *the cock's crowing*), or at daybreak: The four periods of the night correspond to the Roman division of the night into four watches of three hours each and simply mean that the master can return at any time during the night.

Mark 13:37

The passage, originally addressed to the disciples (you, see also 13:5), is also directed to all readers of Mark's Gospel (everyone). • Watch for him! Although 13:32–37 warns about being ready, the early church experienced this vigilance as a joyous anticipation of “that wonderful day when the glory of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ, will be revealed” (Titus 2:13). Even Greek Christians in the first century repeated the Aramaic prayer, *Marana tha* (“Come, Lord,” see 1 Cor 16:22; Rev 22:20) and today, we still “eagerly look forward to his appearing” (2 Tim 4:8).

Mark 14:1–2

The leading priests and the teachers of the law had planned to kill Jesus (see 3:6; 11:18; 12:12). Now their plan reaches its final stage.

Mark 14:1–16.8

The last section of Mark tells the story of the suffering, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

Mark 14:3–9

The story of Jesus' being anointed by a woman in Bethany (14:3–9) sets the scene for events to follow. Luke's account (Luke 7:36–50) is significantly different and might be a different event. This incident took place in Bethany, two miles east of Jerusalem on the lower, eastern slope of the Mount of Olives, where Jesus apparently stayed when he was in Judea (Mark 11:1, 11–12). The home belonged to Simon, a former leper (lepers were isolated from society; perhaps he had been healed by Jesus; see 1:40–45). • eating: Or *reclining*. The meal was a banquet, as indicated by their reclining. A woman (see John 12:3) broke the neck of a sealed, alabaster jar containing expensive perfume (pure nard) and poured it all on Jesus' head (see Exod 29:4–7; 2 Kgs 9:1–6).

Mark 14:4–5

Some (cp. Matt 26:8; John 12:4–5) were indignant over what they considered a waste of the expensive perfume, said to have been worth a year's wages for the average worker. This large amount of money could have been given to the poor, and it was obligatory to remember the poor during Passover.

Mark 14:6–8

Jesus defended the woman's action. That the disciples would always have the poor among them did not minimize Jesus' concern for the poor. The opportunity to minister directly to Jesus was limited. Only hours remained! She chose the best thing she could do with her perfume.

Mark 14:8

Jesus interprets the woman's action. She had anointed his body in preparation for his burial. Whether the woman was consciously motivated by Jesus' imminent death is unclear; her loving act served the purpose Jesus assigned it.

Mark 14:9

Mark's Gospel does not mention the woman's name, but her action is remembered as people share the story of Jesus worldwide (14:6).

Mark 14:10–11

In clear contrast to the woman who anointed Jesus with perfume, Judas Iscariot, one of the Twelve disciples, offered to betray Jesus for money (Matthew 26:15; 27:3, 9).

Mark 14:12

The Jews *sacrificed* the *lamb for Passover* at twilight on the 14th day of the Jewish month of Nisan (Exodus 12:6). This date occurs in March or April each year.

Mark 14:12–32

The preparation for the Passover meal (14:12–16) introduces the story of the Last Supper (14:22–25). • The Last Supper is associated with the Passover meal (14:12, 14, 16; Matt 26:17–19; Luke 22:7–8, 11, 13, 15; cp. John 18:28; 19:14). Many pilgrims celebrated Passover in Jerusalem, where God's Temple was located (see Deut 16:2).

Mark 14:13–15

Jesus' instructions to the disciples are similar to those of 11:2–6, suggesting that Jesus had prearranged a place for eating the Passover and Last Supper with his disciples. Jesus' careful preparations for this meal emphasize its importance. The two disciples were to prepare the Passover meal, which included the lamb (which had to be slaughtered, skinned, cleaned, and roasted over an open fire), unleavened bread, a bowl of salt water, bitter herbs, and a bowl of a fruit puree, or *kharosheth*. Enough wine mixed with water was needed so that Jesus and the disciples could each drink four cups to celebrate God's fourfold blessing (Exod 6:6–7).

Mark 14:17

With the coming of evening, Jesus arrived with the Twelve at the upstairs guest room. “The Twelve” refers to Jesus’ disciples as a group; ten arrived with Jesus, since two of them were already there (14:13).

Mark 14:18

As they were at the table: The Passover was eaten in a reclining position, as were other banquet meals. During the Passover meal, someone (usually the youngest son) would ask the host, “Why is this night different from other nights?” The father or host would then recount the stories of the Passover and the Exodus (Deut 26:5–9). The elements of the Passover meal were symbolic. The Passover lamb served as a reminder of the blood of the sacrificial lambs that protected Israelite homes from the angel of death, who visited the firstborn in Egypt (Exod 12:28–30). Unleavened bread recalled the rapid exodus of God’s people (Exod 12:31–34, 39). The salt water represented the tears of their bondage and the crossing of the Red Sea, and the bitter herbs their slavery. The four cups of wine acknowledged God’s fourfold promise in Exod 6:6–7. • The terrible deed of betraying Jesus was more heinous in that the betrayer was one of those eating with him (see Pss 41:9; 55:12–14).

Mark 14:19

The disciples were shocked and saddened, asking, Am I the one? This is the first they had heard that Jesus would be betrayed (though the reader has known it since 3:19). Jesus maintained his betrayer’s anonymity.

Mark 14:21

must die, as the Scriptures declared: See, e.g., Isa 52:13–53:12. Jesus foreknew this betrayal as part of the divine plan (cp. 8:31–33), but his betrayer was condemned. Jesus and the Gospel writers do not explain how God’s sovereignty and Judas’s human responsibility can coexist, but both are stated without compromise (see John 19:11).

Mark 14:22–25

The Last Supper began with a blessing. In modern practice, Christians ask God to bless the food; Jews in Jesus’ day blessed God for providing the food with the words, “Blessed are you, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who brings forth bread from the earth.” • this is my body. . . . This is my blood: Some understand these words to mean that the bread and wine are transformed into the very body and blood of Jesus (*transubstantiation*); others, that the bread and wine remain bread and wine but that the real presence of Jesus is found in them (*consubstantiation*). In these two views, when one participates in the Lord’s Supper, one actually eats and drinks the body and blood of Jesus. A third view is that

in eating the bread and wine, Christians spiritually feed on Jesus. A fourth view is that the meal is primarily a memorial, and the elements are symbolic of Jesus’ sacrifice on our behalf. See also John 6:53–63 and corresponding study note.

Mark 14:24

The cup of wine represented Jesus’ blood, poured out as a sacrifice (10:45; Isa 53:12). It initiated the covenant that God has made with his people (Luke 22:20; 1 Cor 11:25; see Exod 24:8; Zech 9:11; Heb 9:18–20; 10:26–29). The term many refers to all people (see Mark 10:45; Rom 5:15–19).

Mark 14:25

when I drink it anew: Jesus will have a great banquet (or feast) for his followers when he returns and fully establishes the kingdom of God.

Mark 14:26–27

Then they sang a hymn: It was customary to end the Passover by singing the last part of the *hallel* psalms (Pss 114–118). • The singing of hymns brought the Passover meal and Last Supper to a conclusion, and Jesus and the disciples departed for the Mount of Olives to spend the night. As they proceeded, Jesus told his disciples that they would all desert him, which had to happen because the Scriptures foretold it. • God will strike the Shepherd: As a result, the sheep (the disciples) would be scattered.

Mark 14:28

Despite predictions of their failure, the account included encouragement and hope. After Jesus was raised from the dead, he met the disciples in Galilee (see 16:7), where they were forgiven and restored (see John 21:1–23).

Mark 14:29–31

Peter protested, and Jesus rebuked him, as in 8:32–33. Even though Peter strongly objected, he denied Jesus only a few hours later.

Mark 14:32

Gethsemane means “oil press” in Aramaic. Gethsemane is still full of olive trees today. John 18:1 calls it a garden. Luke 22:39 shows it was a favorite place for Jesus and his disciples.

Mark 14:33–34

Jesus went ahead with Peter, James, and John (5:37–43; 9:2–9; see also 13:3). They asked them to *keep watch* and pray with him, sharing in his distress.

Mark 14:35–36

Jesus fell to the ground to pray because of his deep distress (see [Gen 17:1–3](#); [Lev 9:24](#); [Num 14:5](#); [16:4](#)). Since it was normal to pray out loud, Jesus' prayer was probably overheard by the three disciples, who would not have fallen asleep immediately. • Jesus addressed God as Abba, Father, indicating their close relationship (see [Rom 8:15](#); [Gal 4:6](#)). • Please take this cup . . . from me: In faith, Jesus expressed his own feelings and desires to the Father. It was not only the physical agony of crucifixion that terrified him, but also the unique death that he would experience. He who knew no sin would experience the wrath of God against sin ([Mark 15:34](#); [2 Cor 5:21](#); [Gal 3:13](#)). • Yet I want your will to be done, not mine: Jesus' submission to the Father's will is a model for his followers.

Mark 14:37–38

are you asleep? The question was a rebuke, for Jesus knew that Peter had been sleeping. • Though the spirit is willing to avoid temptation (see [Rom 7:18](#), [22–23](#)), the body (literally *the flesh*, which denotes the general weakness and vulnerability of humanity) is weak.

Mark 14:41–42

The content of Jesus' prayer was probably the same as before (see [14:35–36](#), [39](#)). The third failure of Peter, James, and John to watch and pray recalls Jesus' prediction that Peter would deny him three times ([14:30](#), [66–72](#)). • The words sleep and have your rest can be interpreted as a command, as in the NLT. Others take it as an exclamation ("You are sleeping and resting!"). Still others take it as a rhetorical question ("Are you sleeping and resting?"). • the time (literally *hour*) has come: The passion of Jesus had begun, the hour for pouring out the blood of the sacrificial lamb ([14:24](#)). This statement coincided with the arrival of Judas and the armed crowd seeking to seize Jesus. Jesus was betrayed into the hands of sinners for whom he willingly went to the cross ([2:17](#); [10:45](#); [14:21](#)). • Up, let's be going: Jesus accepted the cup God had given him. He went out to defeat his enemies by dying for them.

Mark 14:43

Judas's treachery in Jesus' arrest is heightened by the reference to him as one of the twelve disciples. Having agreed with the leading priests to betray Jesus at the right time and place ([14:10–11](#)), he led an armed group to seize Jesus secretly at night apart from the people ([14:1–2](#)). Although they wanted to avoid a conflict, the crowd was large enough to quell any resistance by Jesus or his followers (cp. [Luke 22:52](#); [John 18:3](#)).

Mark 14:44–45

Gethsemane was dark, and Jesus was personally unknown to most of the crowd sent to seize him (see [John 18:7–8](#)), so Judas had given a sign by which he would identify Jesus. Judas addressed Jesus as Rabbi and greeted him with a kiss, a common form of greeting ([1 Sam 10:1](#); [2 Sam 19:39](#); [Luke 7:45](#)).

Mark 14:47

Peter tried to defend Jesus by cutting off the ear of the high priest's slave (see [John 18:10](#); see [Luke 22:50–51](#)).

Mark 14:49

But everything happening was to fulfill what the Scriptures say about Jesus. Mark reassured his audience that these events were part of God's plan. See [Isaiah 53:7–9](#).

Mark 14:50

As Jesus had predicted just hours earlier, all his disciples deserted him ([14:27–31](#)).

Mark 14:51–52

The account of the arrest of Jesus ends with a note about an unnamed young man. There is no clear theological reason given for why Mark includes this detail. One possible explanation is that it is a personal detail from Mark himself, but this cannot be confirmed.

Mark 14:53–54

The leading priests, the elders, and the teachers of religious law were not synonymous with the "entire high council" ([14:55](#); [15:1](#)), or Sanhedrin, but they made up a large part of it. Peter followed Jesus into the high priest's courtyard, where the Sanhedrin was meeting. The stage is set for Peter's denial ([14:66–72](#)).

Mark 14:53–65

The story of Jesus' trial follows immediately upon his arrest. Objections have been raised as to the historicity of the various accounts of Jesus' trial, because of differences of detail from the rules found in the Mishnah tractate *Mishnah Sanhedrin*. However, (1) the Mishnah was written around AD 200, whereas the Gospel of Mark was written in the late 60s, over 130 years earlier; (2) the rules found in *Mishnah Sanhedrin* idealize what later rabbis thought should take place in such trials and do not necessarily describe what did in fact take place; (3) it is questionable whether the Sadducees leading the Sanhedrin would have followed the Pharisaic rules found in *Mishnah Sanhedrin* (see [Acts 23:6–10](#)); (4) the rules found in *Mishnah Sanhedrin* sometimes conflict with what the Jewish historian Josephus wrote; (5) existing

laws of conduct were not necessarily followed—Jesus was being tried by a kangaroo court, in which the sentence was predetermined and only the charge for carrying it out was sought (Mark 14:55); (6) if we must choose between the trial accounts found in the Gospels and *Mishnah Sanhedrin*, there is no reason to choose the reliability of *Mishnah Sanhedrin* over that of the Gospels.

Mark 14:55–59

The trial took place before the entire high council (Greek *Sanhedrin*), which had seventy members and was led by the high priest. The Gospels portray a formal trial: There was a search for witnesses (14:55), eyewitness testimony (14:56–59), Jesus being placed under oath (Matt 26:63), Jesus being allowed to defend himself (Mark 14:60), the high priest tearing his robe (14:63), and the concluding verdict by the Sanhedrin (14:64). This does not mean that it was a fair trial—the decision to put Jesus to death had already been made. Evidence was not sought to determine the truth, but to obtain a guilty verdict and death sentence. • False witnesses giving false testimony misrepresented what Jesus said about the destruction and rebuilding of the Temple (see 15:29; John 2:19; Acts 6:14). Because the false witnesses contradicted each other, their testimony was unacceptable (Num 35:30; Deut 17:6; 19:15).

Mark 14:60–61

Because the false witnesses did not agree, the high priest asked Jesus for evidence against himself (14:56).

Mark 14:62

I Am: Cp. study note on 6:49–50. The reader has known from the beginning that Jesus was the Messiah, the Son of God (1:1). This was acknowledged by demons (1:24; 3:11; 5:7), by God (1:11; 9:7), and by the disciples (8:29–30), but this is the first time that Jesus openly and publicly acknowledged that he was the Messiah. • The second part of Jesus' reply was that he would sit in the place of power at God's right hand, which foretold his resurrection and ascension (Luke 24:50–51; Acts 1:9–11; see Phil 2:9; Heb 1:3) and his triumphal coming on the clouds of heaven to judge the world. At Jesus' return, roles will be reversed, and those judging the Son of Man will be judged by him.

Mark 14:63–64

The high priest tore his clothing at Jesus' response. This was a judicial act that indicated a guilty verdict and signified that there was no need to find other witnesses. The rest of the Sanhedrin agreed that Jesus was guilty and deserved to die. • Exactly what was blasphemous in Jesus' reply is unclear. Perhaps it was his reply "I Am," which was the way God referred to himself in Exod 3:14 (see John 8:58). However,

Mark is not necessarily repeating the actual words Jesus said at his trial (cp. Matt 26:64; Luke 22:70), so these words could simply be indicating Jesus' affirmative response to the high priest's question. He was the Messiah, the Son of God. During the second Jewish revolt against Rome, Bar Kokhba (AD 132–135) claimed to be the Messiah, and it was not considered blasphemous. Jesus' identification of himself as the Son of Man cannot have been considered blasphemous, for we have over fifty instances before Jesus' trial in which he used this title, and the charge of blasphemy was never raised. Yet it was too much for the high priest and the Sanhedrin when Jesus clearly claimed to be the Son of Man of Dan 7:13 coming in God's name to judge the world. This declaration was also added to the fact that, during his ministry, Jesus forgave sins (Mark 2:5–7; Luke 7:48–50), claimed to be the Son of God (Mark 12:6), pronounced judgment upon the Temple (14:58), and claimed to be Lord of the Sabbath (2:28). Already convinced that Jesus should be put to death, the religious leaders now pronounced the predetermined guilty verdict (14:55).

Mark 14:65

- *Spit*: See 10:34.
- *Prophecy*: See 6:4, 15; 8:28; 14:58.
- Similar abuse would happen during his trial before Pontius Pilate (15:16–20).

Mark 14:66–72

Peter's predicted denials occurred during the trial of Jesus (see 14:30).

Mark 14:67

The title *Jesus the Nazarene* might have offended some people. People from Judea did not have a good opinion of those from Galilee (John 1:46; 7:41, 52).

Mark 14:68

Peter said he did not know Jesus. To avoid more questions, he left the courtyard and went to *the gateway*.

Mark 14:69–70

The *servant girl* repeated her accusation to standing there. The others thought Peter followed Jesus because he was a *Galilean* (see Matthew 26:73; compare Acts 2:7).

Mark 14:71

When he denied knowing Jesus, Peter promised that he was telling the truth with an oath.

Mark 14:72

When Peter denied Jesus for the third time, the rooster crowed again. This fulfilled the prediction of Jesus from [14:30](#).

While Jesus stood bravely before the Sanhedrin (the Jewish ruling council), Peter became afraid of people with little power. He called down curses on himself and said he did not know Jesus. When Peter remembered what Jesus had said, he began to weep.

Mark 15:1

- *Early in the morning*: Roman trials usually began at the start of the day. It is uncertain if this was a second meeting of *the whole Sanhedrin* or if it refers back to the council's decision in [14:63–64](#) and resumes here.
- Since the *Sanhedrin* could not impose capital punishment ([John 18:31](#)), they took Jesus to Pilate, the Roman governor of Judea from AD 26–36. Pilate usually lived on the coast at Caesarea. But he stayed in Jerusalem during Passover. This was when Israel's celebration of the exodus event increased hopes for freedom from Roman rule.

Mark 15:1–15

After Peter denied Christ, Mark returns to the story of Jesus and his trial. Pilate's hesitating under pressure matches what other sources say about his personality.

Mark 15:2

- The phrase *King of the Jews* is similar to the Jewish title "King of Israel" in [15:32](#).
- *You have said so*: The response Jesus gives to Pilate's question appears in all four Gospels. Jesus clearly understood himself to be a king ([10:37–38](#); [11:9–10](#); [12:35–37](#)). Pilate eventually crucified him for this reason ([15:26](#)). But Pilate knew Jesus was not a political threat ([John 18:33–39](#)).

Mark 15:3–5

Pilate asked Jesus to defend himself against the charges.

Mark 15:6–8

- The *custom* described in [15:6–8](#) is not known outside of the Gospels, but all four Gospels mention it ([Matthew 27:15–21](#); [Luke 23:18–25](#); [John 18:37–40](#)). In many cases, ancient societies released prisoners during special holidays.
- *Barabbas*: See also [Matthew 27:16–17](#); [Luke 23:19](#).
- *who had committed murder during the insurrection*: Pilate's willingness to release Barabbas likely shows that Barabbas had not killed Roman citizens or soldiers ([Matthew 15:15](#)).

Mark 15:9–14

Pilate wanted to release Jesus. However, the crowd became very angry and excited. They would not listen to reason or allow further discussion.

Mark 15:15

- *To satisfy the crowd*: To protect his job, Pilate ordered the crucifixion of an innocent man.
- *he had Jesus flogged*: Flogging (severe beating) usually came before crucifixion. Soldiers used leather straps with pieces of metal, stone, or bone attached. These blows tore the skin and could even cause death.

This fulfilled what Jesus had predicted earlier in [10:34](#).

Mark 15:16

the whole company: This was literally *a cohort*, which was one-tenth of a Roman legion of soldiers, or about 600 men. Those called to attend were likely all the soldiers on duty in the Praetorium.

Mark 15:16–41

The crucifixion story is one of the most historically reliable events from ancient history. Why would the early church invent a story where its central figure died as a criminal? This story was offensive to Jews and seemed ridiculous to non-Jews ([1 Corinthians 1:23](#)).

Mark 15:17

a purple robe: Purple cloth, made with an expensive dye, was worn by royalty and other wealthy individuals ([Luke 16:19](#); [1 Maccabees 10:20, 62](#); [11:58](#)). This *purple robe* might have been a centurion's old robe.

Mark 15:18

King of the Jews: This was the official charge for which the Romans declared Jesus guilty ([15:2, 26](#)).

Mark 15:21–22

- After they left the walled city of Jerusalem, Jesus became too weak to carry his cross. The Roman soldiers forced *Simon of Cyrene* (a city in northern Africa) to carry it (see [Matthew 5:41](#)).

Usually, a person being crucified had to carry the horizontal crossbeam (called the *patibulum*) to the place of execution. The vertical post (called the *stipes*) was often left in the ground as a warning to others (like a hangman's scaffold in a public square).

- *Simon of Cyrene, the father of Alexander and Rufus*: These men were probably known to Mark's audience (see [Romans 16:13](#)).

- *Golgotha* is an Aramaic word, meaning *The Place of the Skull*. In the Latin Vulgate, “skull” is *calvariae* (“Calvary”). In the time of Jesus, Golgotha was outside the walls of Jerusalem ([John 19:20](#); see [Matthew 27:32](#); [Hebrews 13:12](#)). When Herod Antipas later enlarged the city with the so-called third wall, Golgotha was enclosed.

Mark 15:23

- It is uncertain if people offered Jesus *wine mixed with myrrh* as a kind act or to mock him ([Proverbs 31:6](#)). Jesus refused the calming drink mixture because he had committed himself to accept the suffering God had given him ([Mark 10:38–39](#); [14:36](#)).
- People have used myrrh since before the time of Jesus to treat wounds, infections, and digestive problems.

Mark 15:24

- Crucifixion began with the Medes and Persians in the 600s BC. It spread to the eastern Mediterranean in the 300s BC through Alexander the Great. It became the main form of capital punishment in the Roman Empire until AD 337, when Constantine banned the practice.

Crucifixion was slow, shameful, and full of pain. Sometimes a victim stayed alive for several days. Birds and dogs might even begin to eat the body before the person died. A victim could be tied to the cross with ropes or fastened with nails. Nails were used in the crucifixion of Jesus ([Luke 24:39](#); [John 20:25, 27](#); see [Colossians 2:14](#)). To prevent early death from loss of breathing, a place to rest the feet or a seat was often added to the post.

- All four Gospels report that the soldiers *divided his garments* among themselves.

Mark 15:25

Mark states that they crucified Jesus at *the third hour*, which is nine o'clock in the morning. [John 19:14](#) mentions the time as around the sixth hour, or noon. These are approximate times. They would often describe events in the late morning as happening around the third hour ([Matthew 20:3](#); [Acts 2:15](#)) or sixth hour ([Mark 15:33](#); [Matthew 20:5](#); [27:45](#); [Luke 23:44](#); [John 4:6](#); [19:14](#); [Acts 10:9](#)).

Mark 15:26

Although the title *King of the Jews* was meant to mock Jesus, Mark presents it as true and full of meaning.

Mark 15:27

two robbers: Jesus, the most important figure, was placed in the center. This position drew attention to him.

Mark 15:29–32

- Jesus was being mocked and abused by those who passed by, the religious leaders, and those who were crucified with Jesus.
- *those who passed by heaped abuse* (literally *they blasphemed*): They shook their heads to show contempt (see [Lamentations 2:15](#)). They also mocked his claim that he would destroy the temple (see [Mark 14:58](#)).

Mark 15:32

The two men who were crucified with Jesus also mocked him. One might expect them to show compassion, since they were suffering the same cruel punishment (see [Luke 23:39–43](#)).

Mark 15:33

From the sixth hour until the ninth hour darkness came over all the land: The whole land likely refers to all of Judah. The *darkness* was both real and symbolic. It showed the evil nature of what was happening and gave a sign of the judgment that Jesus said would come on Israel (see [13:1–31](#); [14:58](#); [15:29](#)).

Mark 15:34

- *Eloi, Eloi ... why have You forsaken me*: Jesus cried out loudly. Mark records his words in Aramaic (the language Jesus spoke) and then gives the meaning in Greek.
- “*My God, My God, why have you forsaken me?*”: Jesus is quoting [Psalm 22:1](#). This statement should be understood by considering [Mark 14:27](#), [Psalm 22](#), [Isaiah 53:10](#), [2 Corinthians 5:21](#), and [Galatians 3:13](#). At this moment, God’s purpose was being fulfilled. Jesus was giving his life as “a ransom for many” ([Mark 10:45](#)).

Mark 15:35–36

The Aramaic word *Eloi* and the Hebrew form *Eli* ([Matthew 27:46](#)) sound similar to the name Elijah. Because of this, some people standing nearby thought Jesus was calling for the prophet Elijah to come and rescue him (see [Malachi 4:5](#)).

Mark 15:37

The death of Jesus, like the crucifixion, is told with stark simplicity. The Gospel account gives only a few direct details.

Mark 15:38

The *veil of the temple ... torn in two* might have been one of two curtains. It may have been the curtain that separated the sanctuary from the courtyard. This curtain was a large and beautiful tapestry about 23 meters tall (80 feet). Or it may

have been the inner curtain that separated the Most Holy Place (the most sacred room) from the rest of the sanctuary.

If it was the outer curtain, people could have seen it tear (compare the “darkness” in [15:33](#)). This would show that the prediction of Jesus about the destruction of the sanctuary ([14:58](#); [15:29](#)) was already beginning to happen in a spiritual way (see [Rom 9–11](#)). The full physical destruction would come later, in AD 70.

If it was the inner curtain, the tearing likely had a different meaning. Just as the heavens opened at the baptism of Jesus to show his direct access to God (see study note on Mark 1:10), his death now made that access possible for his followers (see [Hebrews 6:19–20](#); [9:3–14](#); [10:19–20](#)).

Mark 15:39

- *The centurion*: The Latin word *centurion* refers to an officer in charge of 100 men.
- Jesus as the *Son of God* was announced by many voices. God declared it ([1:11](#); [9:7](#)). Demons also recognized it ([1:24](#), [34](#); [3:11](#); [5:7](#)). Mark states it at the beginning of the Gospel ([1:1](#)). Jesus himself speaks about it ([12:6](#); [13:32](#); [14:61–62](#)). Now, a Gentile (non-Jewish) officer also declares it.

Mark 15:40–41

- These *women* helped meet some of the financial needs of Jesus (see [Luke 8:2–3](#)). They were present at the burial and the empty tomb ([Mark 15:47](#); [16:1–8](#)). They were the first to witness the resurrection of Jesus.
- Mary Magdalene was from the village of Magdala near the Sea of Galilee. She is a key figure in the resurrection stories ([16:1](#), [9](#); [Matthew 28:1](#); [Luke 24:10](#); [John 20:1](#), [11–18](#)).
- *Mary the mother of James the younger*: This James might have been James son of Alphaeus ([Mark 3:18](#)).
- Salome is mentioned only here and in [Mark 16:1](#).

Mark 15:43–45

Joseph of Arimathea: He was possibly from Ramathaim, a village about 32 kilometers (20 miles) northwest of Jerusalem. A respected member of the Jewish high council (Sanhedrin), he was also a secret follower of Jesus. He was waiting for the kingdom of God to come (see [Matthew 27:57](#); [Luke 23:50–51](#); [John 19:38](#)). He bravely asked Pilate for the body of Jesus so he could bury it.

As a *prominent Council member* who was not known as a disciple, his request supported Rome’s interests. This addressed Jewish concerns about leaving the dead exposed after sunset ([Deuteronomy 21:22–23](#)). It also prevented the disciples of Jesus from receiving the body.

Mark 15:46

Joseph prepared the body of Jesus for burial and laid it in his own tomb (see [Matthew 27:60](#)).

Mark 16:1

- At sunset, when the Sabbath day ended, the shops opened again. The women “bought spices so they could go and anoint the body of Jesus” ([16:1](#)). They intended to reduce the smell of the dead body.
- The women did not expect Jesus to resurrect from the dead. Even the empty tomb did not convince them of his resurrection ([John 20:2](#), [11–15](#)).

Mark 16:3–4

The women wondered how to move the large stone covering the tomb. God had already moved the stone to let them and the other disciples enter.

Mark 16:7

The angel’s message to the disciples repeated what Jesus had already said ([14:28](#)). It reminded them of his promise.

The disciples had abandoned Jesus and denied him, but they would be forgiven. Their role as apostles (messengers sent by Jesus) would be restored.

Mark 16:8

- The story ends with the women running away from the tomb. They were shaking with fear and confused (not sure what was happening).
- *they did not say a word to anyone*: This can be understood in two ways. It may be positive. The women may not have spoken to others because they were focused on their task to tell the disciples ([16:7](#); compare [Luke 10:4](#); [2 Kings 4:29](#)).

Or it may be negative. The women may have failed to deliver the message at that moment (compare [Luke 24:5–11](#); [John 20:1–2](#), [18](#)).

Mark 16:9–20

Nearly all scholars agree that Mark did not write the shorter ending and the longer ending of his Gospel. These endings use different styles, vocabulary, and theology (teaching about God). Also, the two best early Greek manuscripts (*Codex Sinaiticus* and *Codex Vaticanus*) do not include these endings.

However, many scholars also doubt that Mark meant to end his Gospel at [16:8](#). Several reasons support this view:

1. Mark emphasizes that the predictions of Jesus are fulfilled. If the Gospel ends at [16:8](#), there is no account of Jesus appearing after his resurrection.

2. All the other Gospels include stories of Jesus appearing to the women and the disciples.
3. Some early manuscripts include added endings. This suggests that some early copyists (people who copied texts by hand) thought the Gospel needed a clearer ending.
4. There is no clear reason why Mark would choose to end at 16:8. Many suggested reasons come from modern ways of reading, not from how a first-century Christian writer would likely think.
5. The Gospel begins with a strong statement that Jesus is the Messiah (1:1), but ending at 16:8 would leave the story with fear instead of resolution.
6. The Greek word *gar* (“because”) appears at the end of 16:8. It is very unusual for an ancient Greek book to end with this word.
7. Mark 16:7 suggests the disciples will meet Jesus in Galilee. If 16:8 was the original ending, it would be the only prediction in the Gospel that did not come true.

Because of these reasons, many scholars think the original ending was lost (for example, the last page may have been damaged or removed) or that Mark did not finish writing it.